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THE PHONE-FIRST EDITION

02

The Freelancer Starter System

How to Get Your First Paying Client Online

Build the profile, portfolio and outreach system that win a first paying client.

10 copy-ready scripts | Portfolio without clients | Payment routes explained

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GLOBAL EDITION · FIRST EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

The Freelancer Starter System

How to Get Your First Paying Client Online

LEGAL, DISCLAIMER AND HOW TO READ THIS

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The local Freelancer Starter System — First Edition · September 2026

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What this course is

A practical, your country-specific operating manual for getting a first paying client as a freelancer. It covers how the freelance market actually behaves, how to pick one skill and one buyer, how to build a profile that reads like an offer rather than a CV, how to build three labelled sample projects when you have no clients, four channels for finding work, ten copy-ready scripts, how to answer objections without dropping your price, how to deliver the work, and exactly how money reaches a resident of a country with limited payment access — locally and from abroad.

Every figure is traceable to a published source listed in the Sources & Further Reading section, or is clearly labelled as an example.

What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not legal, tax, financial or investment advice. It is not a list of platforms that will approve you. It does not guarantee a client, a reply, a price, a payout method or a result of any kind.

It cannot tell you what a platform, a bank, a payment provider or a government office will decide about your specific case. That depends on your documents, your record and the rules in force on the day you apply.

FINANCIAL AND LEGAL DISCLAIMER

Nothing in this course is a guarantee of income. Any figure that looks like earnings is a **target example or arithmetic illustration, never a prediction**. Every price shown US US dollars (USD) is an example for teaching purposes; what you can charge depends on your market, your buyer and your proof.

You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you use. Rules, fees, limits, payout availability and country eligibility change without much warning. Verify anything you intend to rely on, on the official page, before you invest time or money in it.

This is not financial, legal or investment advice. For anything with a legal or tax consequence — licensing, TIN, turnover tax, VAT, contracts — confirm with your national tax authority or a qualified professional.

FICTIONAL EXAMPLES AND FIGURES

Every business, message, price and project in this course is invented to teach a method. Where a business name appears it is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. No real, recognisable local company is used as a client, a buyer or a success story anywhere in this course.

Figures cited are current as of **September 2026** unless a specific date is printed next to the figure. Source URLs for every statistic appear in the Sources & Further Reading section at the back of this course. Where this course could not verify a fact, it says so and tells you to check it yourself.

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Last updated: September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

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HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.

FRONT MATTER

Before You Start

This course teaches one thing: how an local with one decent skill gets a first paying client online, and how the money actually reaches them afterwards.

What this course can help you do

— Understand how the freelance market really behaves, and why price is the wrong weapon for a beginner.

— Choose one skill and one buyer type instead of offering everything to everyone.

— Write a profile that reads like an offer, not like a CV.

— Build three clearly labelled sample projects so you have proof before you have clients.

— Find real buyers through four specific channels that work where you live today.

— Send outreach and proposals that a busy owner will actually finish reading.

— Answer the eight objections you will hear, without panicking or cutting your price in half.

— Deliver work with a scope document, so revisions do not eat your week.

— Get paid by local clients and by foreign clients through routes that are legal and verified.

— Run a 14-day launch plan and a 30-proposal cadence you can track in one Google Sheet.

What this course cannot promise

READ THIS PART TWICE

This course cannot promise that a client will reply, that a client will pay, or that you will earn any particular amount. It cannot promise that a platform will accept your registration or release a payout to you. It cannot promise that a foreign client will agree to a remittance transfer instead of the payment tool they normally use.

What it gives you is a method and a set of words. Whether the method produces a client depends partly on your skill, partly on how many messages you send, and partly on luck. Any course that removes luck from that sentence is not being honest with you.

What you need to start

YOU NEED	NOTES	REQUIRED?
A smartphone with a data bundle	An Android phone runs this entire course. Published indicative bundle prices are around $0.60 for about 2 GB and around $5 for about 30 GB per month. Bundle prices changed during 2025 and will change again — check your own plan.	Yes
Occasional laptop access	Useful for PDF portfolio layout, spreadsheet work and video trimming. Not required. A friend's laptop, a family computer or an internet cafe works.	Recommended
One skill you are decent at	Writing, design, Sheets or Excel, video editing, translation, research, admin, basic coding. Decent means you can produce something a stranger would pay a small amount for.	Yes

YOU NEED	NOTES	REQUIRED?
A way to receive money	An active a mobile wallet, a mobile-money wallet, a mobile wallet, a bank wallet or a bank wallet wallet, or a bank account in your own name. Never rent or borrow anyone else's.	Yes, by section 08

YOU NEED	NOTES	REQUIRED?
A professional email address	Free to create. Section 03 gives the exact setup and the signature wording.	Yes

YOU NEED	NOTES	REQUIRED?
A business licence	Not needed for wallet or bank transfers from local clients. Needed later if you want a merchant gateway or a service-exporter account.	No, not at the start

Time commitment

Plan on **about 90 minutes a day for 14 days** to build the skill positioning, the profile, the portfolio and the prospect list. Section 10 gives that plan day by day.

After day 14, the honest commitment drops to **about 60 minutes a day for outreach**: roughly five researched messages, or two platform proposals, plus follow-ups and one improvement to your portfolio. Outreach is not a one-week event. It is a habit that continues until a client says yes.

If you can only give 30 minutes a day, the course still works. Everything doubles in calendar time, and section 10 tells you which days can be merged.

Free tools this course uses

01 Google Docs and Drive

For the one-page PDF portfolio, the scope document and the invoice. Drive gives you a view-only share link that works from a phone. Free.

02 Google Sheets

For the prospect list, the proposal tracker and the invoice log. One spreadsheet runs the whole business at the start. Free, and it works offline on mobile once opened.

03 A free design tool

For menus, posters, price lists and portfolio pages. Free plans change their limits; verify the current free limits before you build a workflow on any tool.

04 CapCut, InShot or VN Editor

Android video editors available on the Play Store for cutting client clips. All three have usable free tiers. InShot lets you watch an advert to remove the watermark.

05 Google Maps

Your main prospecting surface. It is where local businesses are listed, with phone numbers, photos, reviews and opening hours you can inspect before you make contact.

06 Telegram

For business communities, for sending files, and for one of the fastest ways to receive money locally. Free, and light on data.

Free tiers and bundle prices change. Verify current limits and prices before you depend on any tool.

If you are not in your city

Most of this course assumes nothing about your city. Prospecting happens on Google Maps, Telegram, LinkedIn and email, and every one of those works from a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city or a regional city.

Two things differ outside Addis. First, the number of large advertisers is smaller, so local clients pay less and you should aim more of your outreach at clients in other cities or abroad. Second, in-person meetings are less useful as a sales tool, so your written message has to carry more weight. Section 06 is written for that.

THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE

Do not read this course without sending messages.

The failure pattern is always the same. Someone buys a course, reads it in two evenings, feels informed, and sends nothing. Three months later they say freelancing does not work where you live. Nothing was ever tested.

Outreach is uncomfortable, especially the first ten messages. Your English may feel shaky. You may worry that the owner will laugh at you. That discomfort does not go away before you start; it goes away after about the twentieth message, and the only route there is through the first nineteen.

The rule is simple: for every section you finish, send one real message before you start the next one. By the end of the course that is ten messages sent, and ten messages is already a real business experiment.

One more thing. Your first fifteen messages will probably get no reply. That is not a verdict on you. It is the normal shape of cold outreach, everywhere in the world, for everyone, including people who have been doing it for years.

If you remember one sentence from this course, remember this: **a mediocre portfolio that gets sent to thirty prospects beats a perfect portfolio that nobody has seen.**

FRONT MATTER

Who This Is For, and Who It Is Not For

This course is for you if

— You are roughly 20 to 32 and you have **one skill you are decent at** — writing, design, Sheets or Excel, video editing, translation, research, admin, or coding basics.

— You have never sold that skill to a stranger, and you have never had a client.

— You have no portfolio, no reviews, and no idea whether you can even get paid.

— You can give this about 90 minutes a day for two weeks, then about an hour a day after that.

— You are willing to send messages to people who have not asked to hear from you.

— You are in your city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, or anywhere else with a working phone signal.

— You want **clients** — paid project work — rather than a salaried job.

This course is not for you if

— You want a salary, a contract and a monthly payslip. That is a different and equally valid path, and Course 07 is the one you want.

— You want income without doing the work. There is no such thing, and anyone selling it to you is selling something else.

— You will not message a stranger. Every channel in section 05 requires it.

— You want to sell a service you have not learned yet. Learn it first; this course is about selling what you can already do.

— You are looking for advice on faking your location, renting an account or using crypto to receive money. This course will not help you with any of that, and section 08 explains why it is a bad idea rather than a clever one.

AN HONEST NOTE ABOUT JOBS AND GIGS

Nothing here says freelancing is better than employment. A salaried job is steadier, comes with a desk and colleagues, and pays at the end of the month whether or not a stranger answers your message. Many people do both at once.

Freelancing is worth learning because it is **portable, it compounds, and it does not require anyone's permission to start**. If you would rather have a job, read Course 07 — The Remote Work Starter System. The two courses share the profile and portfolio work, so nothing you build here is wasted.

FRONT MATTER

What You Will Be Able to Do, and How to Use This Course

The eight outcomes of this course

BY THE END YOU CAN	YOU WILL HAVE PRODUCED	SECTION
Explain the market honestly to yourself	A one-page reality note on what you are competing against	01
Name your service in one sentence	A completed skills inventory and opportunity score	02
Describe yourself as an offer	Five written bio versions and a profile headline	03
Show proof without clients	Three labelled sample projects in one shareable PDF	04
Find buyers yourself	A Google Sheet with 50 named prospects and contact routes	05
Write outreach that gets read	Ten saved message templates, personalised and sent	06
Hold your price	A written price list and answers to eight objections	07
Deliver and get paid legally	A scope document, an invoice template and a payment route you have tested	08

Four ways to run the course

Phone only

Everything in this course can be done on an Android phone. Write in Google Docs, build samples in a free design app, keep your prospect list in Google Sheets, send files by Telegram or Drive link. The only tasks that are genuinely painful on a phone are laying out a multi-page PDF and trimming long video, and section 04 gives phone alternatives for both.

Laptop, when you can borrow one

Borrow or rent a laptop for two sessions if you can: one to build the PDF portfolio, one to build the prospect sheet. Everything else stays on the phone. Do not postpone the course waiting for a laptop.

Low-data mode

Do the reading offline. Turn off autoplay. Never upload raw video: compress first, or send a share link to a compressed copy. Do your uploads before 16:00 or after midnight. Section 01 explains why the timing matters.

When the connection dies

Prepare a second route before you need it: a second SIM, a neighbour's hotspot you have permission to use, or a nearby cafe. Section 01 gives the written note that tells clients what you will do if a call drops, which removes their main worry about hiring someone where you live.

Translation: finding a client starts with sending a message. If you do not know your own service in detail, talking about price becomes difficult. So choose the one service you will do first, then go looking for the buyer.

FRONT MATTER

If You Only Have 5 Hours

Some readers will not finish a 14-day plan. If you have five hours total, do exactly this and nothing else. It is the shortest route to a real experiment.

TIME	DO THIS	OUTPUT
Hour 1	Read section 02. Complete the skills inventory. Score your top three service ideas with the eight-factor opportunity score. Pick one.	One written sentence: "I do `[service]` for `[buyer]`."
Hour 2	Read section 03. Write the one-line bio and the short bio. Create the professional email address. Paste the signature.	A profile paragraph you can reuse everywhere
Hour 3	Read section 04. Build one sample project — not three. One is enough to start. Label it clearly as a sample. Export it as a PDF or a single image set.	One shareable link
Hour 4	Read section 05. Open Google Maps. Build a list of 20 named local businesses with phone numbers or Instagram handles. Save it in Google Sheets with five columns.	20 named prospects
Hour 5	Read section 06. Copy the local cold outreach script. Personalise it 20 times with one specific observation each. Send all 20. Then read section 07 and save the objection answers to your notes.	20 messages sent

WHAT YOU ARE SKIPPING

In the fast path you skip the second and third sample projects, the international-client profile, the platform channel, the negotiation practice, the scope document, and the full payment chapter. Those are not optional forever — they are what turn a first reply into a first payment. Come back to them the week after your first reply, not before.

If five hours is still too much, do hour 4 and hour 5 only. A prospect list and twenty sent messages teach you more about this market than any amount of reading.

FRONT MATTER

The Money Question, Answered First

This is the fear that stops most local readers before they start, so it goes at the front of the course, not the back.

The fear sounds like this: "*Even if I find a client, how would the money actually reach me? I have no PayPal. Stripe is not available here. Nobody is going to send cash to a stranger in Addis.*"

The fear is reasonable, and the answer is more specific than most courses admit. The money question is **not one problem**. It is two different problems, and they have two different solutions.

Problem one: a local local client

This one is smaller than you think. A local client can pay you from their a mobile wallet, a mobile-money wallet, a mobile wallet, a bank wallet, a bank wallet or a bank wallet wallet, or by bank transfer to your account. **You do not need a business licence to receive that money as an individual.**

There are limits. Under the your central bank or financial regulator directive your payment-system rules, a Level 2 wallet has a maximum daily balance of $950 an aggregate daily transaction limit of $1,900 a daily person-to-person transfer limit of $450 and two-factor authentication is required above $120. In practice, for a beginner charging a few thousand dollars per project, these limits are not the constraint.

Problem two: a foreign client

This is the harder one, and here is the honest position.

> WHAT IS NOT VERIFIED
>
> There is **no verified route for a resident of a country with limited payment access to hold a PayPal, Payoneer, Wise or Stripe receiving account** and bill foreign clients through it. PayPal Inc appears on the your central bank or financial regulator's licensed remittance list — but that covers inbound money transfers into your country, which is a different question from a resident of a country with limited payment access holding a PayPal account to invoice clients. Payoneer's country page could not be read, and this course will not guess.
>
> If you find advice telling you to open one of these with a foreign address, a VPN, or someone else's documents: that is misrepresentation, it puts your money and your identity at risk, and this course does not teach it.

What does work

The clearly verified inbound route is an **your regulator-licensed remittance corridor**. Your client sends the money through a licensed money-transfer operator — Western Union, MoneyGram, Ria, Remitly, WorldRemit, Taptap Send, TalkRemit, Xpress Money, Transfast, Thunes or Alansari — or through a wallet corridor such as a wallet remittance corridor, a wallet remittance corridor or a mobile-money wallet. You collect it as cash, as a bank deposit, or as wallet credit in dollars. MoneyGram's own your country page confirms cash pickup, bank account and mobile wallet as receiving options.

The cost of that route is real and you should know it before you quote a price: **the sender pays the remittance fee plus the foreign-exchange spread**. That is why a foreign client paying you $8,000 may be charged noticeably more than $8,000 on their side. Section 08 explains how to structure your price so this does not become an argument.

Beyond that, there is an upgrade route: register a TIN, then a business licence, then a service-exporter registration. Under Directive service-export rules a registered service exporter may retain 100% of foreign-currency earnings indefinitely, and banks may issue an international Mastercard or Visa without travel documents.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU TODAY

You can start today, with no licence and no TIN, and get paid by local clients through a wallet or a bank transfer. That is enough to earn your first money and build proof.

You can also serve foreign clients today, but you must agree the payment route with them **before** you start work, and it will usually be a remittance corridor. Say it early, in writing, and most clients cooperate — they have used Western Union or Remitly before.

Everything else — merchant gateways such as a local card-and-wallet gateway, a local payment gateway and a local payment gateway, service-exporter accounts and international cards — requires a registered business with a trade licence, a TIN and a Memorandum of Association. That is a later step, not a starting condition. **Section 08 is the full chapter, with the limits, the fees and the exact wording to use with a client.**

01

SECTION ONE

What Freelancing From your country Actually Is

An honest look at the market you are entering: how crowded it is, why buyers behave the way they do, what the connectivity situation costs you in practice, and the five counter-moves that turn a weak connection from an excuse into a managed risk.

01 The economics, without the hype

02 Where a beginner actually wins

03 your country-specific friction: speed, cost and timing

04 Five counter-moves that neutralise the connectivity problem

05 The "how I work" note that removes a client's main worry

Before you write a single message, you need an accurate picture of the market. Not a discouraging one — an accurate one. Most people who fail at this fail because they were sold a picture that was too optimistic, then quit when reality arrived. This section gives you reality first.

You will finish it knowing what you are competing against, what your real advantage is as a beginner, and exactly how to describe your working conditions to a client in a way that builds trust instead of losing the job.

01. The Economics, Without the Hype

Freelancing is a market, and markets have supply and demand. On the supply side, the number of people offering services online is enormous and it grew fast. On the demand side, buyers are cautious, because hiring a stranger for the first time is a risk they are taking with their own money and their own reputation.

Three things follow from that, and they are true everywhere, not only where you live.

EXPLAIN Buyers are risk-averse. A business owner choosing between two people with similar skills will almost always choose the one who looks like they have done this exact job before. That is why reviews and a portfolio matter so much, and why getting the first client is the hardest one.

SHOW Example scenario — fictional. Two designers both offer a menu redesign at $12. One sends a message that says "I am a graphic designer, I can design your menu." The other sends: "Your Google Maps photos show a menu from 2023 with no prices. I redesigned your lunch page as a sample — it is attached. I can do the full menu in four days for $12." The second one is not more talented. They are less risky to hire.

DO Stop thinking about how to look more skilled and start thinking about how to look like **less of a risk**. Every section after this one is a risk-reduction technique.

CHECK Can you finish this sentence about your own service? "The reason a cautious buyer can hire me without worry is [specific evidence or guarantee]." If not, you have not finished section 04.

Where a beginner actually wins

A beginner cannot win on experience, reviews, brand, or team size. A beginner also cannot win on price, and this is the part most people get wrong.

> **WHY COMPETING ON PRICE FAILS**
>
> If your only argument is "I am cheaper", then you have permanently capped your income at the lowest number in the market, and you are in a race with everyone else who made the same decision. Worse, low prices signal low quality to a cautious buyer, so the strategy attracts exactly the clients who will demand the most work for the least money.

A beginner wins on two things instead.

01 Specificity

Not "I do social media", but "I write and schedule twelve Facebook posts a month for cafés and restaurants." Not "I do translation", but "I translate product labels and packaging text between the local language and English." A specific offer is straightforward to say yes to, because the buyer can picture the result.

02 Speed

A large agency answers in three days and delivers in three weeks. You can answer in twenty minutes and deliver a small job tomorrow. For a small local business that needs a menu printed before the weekend, speed is worth more than a portfolio.

your country-specific friction, stated plainly

You are not competing on a level field, and pretending otherwise wastes your time. Here are the numbers, with sources.

MEASURE	VALUE	WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU
Median fixed-line download speed	9.37 Mbps	Fine for text, email, spreadsheets and small images. Painful for large file transfers.
Average mobile download speed	26.63 Mbps	Faster than fixed line on a good day, on a good network, at a good hour.
Worst-case freelancer speeds reported	98 Kb/s	This is the number that loses jobs. It is not the average; it is what happens at the wrong hour.
Worst window	16:00–24:00	Plan uploads outside this window. Schedule them, do not attempt them live.
Indicative bundle prices	$0.60 / 2 GB $5 / 30 GB	Cheap at the low end, expensive at the high end. Heavy freelancers have reported data costs up to $19 a month.
Price movement, Dec 2025	Safaricom +44% avg	Data costs are not stable. Ethio telecom kept low-income bundles unchanged and raised the a mobile wallet SuperApp bundle discount from 10% to 20%.

Sources: DataReportal Digital 2026: your country; Addis Fortune connectivity reporting (Aug 2025); Awajis Ethio telecom bundle guide (indicative); Dollars Metrics (Dec 2025). Figures are current as of September 2026.

Two things follow from those numbers, and freelancers in countries like yours have reported both to local business press: **paid work lost to a failed upload**, and **overseas clients asking for an internet speed test screenshot before they will sign a contract**. The second one is worth sitting with. A client who has been burned once will not take your word for it.

> **THE REFRAME**

You cannot fix national infrastructure. You can make your connectivity **irrelevant to the delivery**, and you can make your handling of it **evidence that you are organised**. A person who writes "here is what happens if my connection drops" sounds more professional than a person who promises it will never happen.

Five Counter-Moves

These five moves remove almost all of the risk that a slow connection creates. Each one takes minutes to set up.

1. **Keep file sizes small on purpose**

   Deliver a 1 MB PDF instead of a 40 MB one. Export video at 720p rather than 4K unless the client asked for more. Compress images before sending. A smaller file that arrives is worth more than a beautiful file that fails at 90%. On Android, most gallery and file-manager apps include a resize or compress option; use it before every upload.

2. **Make text the primary deliverable**

   Send the substance as text in the message or as a Google Doc, and the pretty version as an attachment. If the attachment fails, the client still has the work and you still get paid. This single habit has saved more local freelance payments than any technical fix.

3. **Schedule uploads outside 16:00–24:00**

   Send client files early morning or late at night, when the reported worst-case speeds recover. If a deadline lands inside the bad window, upload the night before. Tell the client the file will arrive by a specific hour, then beat it.

4. **Have a second connection**

   A second SIM on a different network is the cheapest insurance in this business. If that is not possible, identify one place within walking distance with working wi-fi — a cafe, a hotel lobby, a friend's office — and know its opening hours before you need it.

5. **Send the "how I work" note before they ask**

   Put it in your proposal, your profile and your first reply. It answers the connectivity worry in writing, on your terms, before the client raises it as a reason not to hire you.

COPY-READY: THE "HOW I WORK" NOTE

How I work

I am based in [city], your country (GMT+3), and I work with clients in other time zones every week.

Updates. You get a written update every [two days] with what is finished and what is next. Updates are text first, so they arrive even on a slow connection.

Files. I keep every delivery small and compressed, and I send a share link as well as the file. If a download fails on your side, the link still works.

Deadlines. I deliver by the agreed hour and I upload the day before if the file is large. If anything on my side is at risk, you hear it from me at least 24 hours before the deadline, not after it.

Calls. I can do voice or video calls. If my connection drops, I will send a written summary of everything we covered within the hour, so nothing is lost.

Revisions. [Two] rounds of revisions are included. I confirm the scope in writing before starting.

What the market pays, for calibration only

You need a sense of scale, not a forecast. These are real local income anchors from published sources.

11,500
USD/MONTH — FEDERAL CIVIL SERVICE, DEGREE-HOLDER ENTRY

6,000
USD/MONTH — CIVIL SERVICE SCALE MINIMUM

6,000–15,000
USD/MONTH — PLANNING PROXY FOR YOUNG URBAN WHITE-COLLAR WORK (ESTIMATE)

Sources: Addis Standard via allAfrica (Sept 2025 pay rise); wage.is; the 6,000–15,000 band is a planning estimate, not a published statistic. For comparison, an industrial-park garment worker is reported at around $11 a month.

TARGET EXAMPLE — NOT A PREDICTION

```
2 projects × $25 = $8,000
minus data $4 = $7,400
```

This is arithmetic, not a forecast. Two projects a month at $25 is a reasonable first target. It is not a promise, and it is not what most people earn in month one.

Translation: do not let the client worry when the internet drops. Send the work as text, keep the file small, and send it early.

Section 01 checklist

- [ ] I can explain, in one sentence, why I am not competing on price.
- [ ] I have written my own "how I work" note and saved it where I can paste it in seconds.
- [ ] I know which hours my own connection is worst, from my own experience, not from a graph.
- [ ] I have identified a backup connection and I know when it is open.
- [ ] I have set my phone's camera or export settings to produce smaller files by default.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

02

SECTION TWO

Choose Your Skill and Your Niche

A worksheet-driven method for turning a general ability into one sellable service for one type of buyer, with ten realistic local service niches, an eight-factor opportunity score, and a written positioning sentence you will use everywhere.

01 A skill is not a service

02 The skills inventory worksheet

03 The one-skill, one-buyer, one-problem rule

04 Ten realistic service niches for locals

05 The eight-factor opportunity score

06 Writing your positioning sentence

Almost every beginner skips this section because it feels slower than sending messages. Then they send messages that say "I can do design, writing, translation, data entry and social media" and hear nothing back.

The buyer is not being difficult. A person offering five things looks like a person who is good at none of them. This section fixes that, using a worksheet and a scoring method, and it takes about ninety minutes.

02. A Skill Is Not a Service

A **skill** is something you can do. A **service** is a result you deliver, to a defined buyer, for a price, within a stated time. Skills do not sell. Services do.

SKILL	SERVICE	WHO BUYS IT
I know Canva	A priced, printable menu redesign delivered in four days	Cafes and restaurants with an old or photographed menu
I write well	Twelve scheduled Facebook posts a month, written and queued	Shops that post once every two months
I speak English	the local language to English translation of product labels and packaging text	Importers, exporters and small manufacturers
I am good at Excel	A daily sales and expense sheet that produces a monthly total	Small shops and kiosks tracking money in a notebook
I can edit video	Six edited 30-second clips a month from footage the client sends	Gyms, salons, tour operators, clothing shops

All rows are illustrations of method. Business types are generic and no real company is referenced.

The Skills Inventory Worksheet

Write on paper or in your phone's notes app. Do not skip to the score; the writing is what makes the score meaningful.

Skill 1 — what I can do .....

Evidence it is real .....

Skill 2 — what I can do .....

Evidence it is real .....

Skill 3 — what I can do .....

Evidence it is real .....

"Evidence it is real" means something you have already made: a design a friend used, a document you wrote for a class or an office, a spreadsheet that saved you hours, a translated page, a video you edited for a cousin's shop. It does not have to be paid work. It has to exist.

THEN ANSWER THESE FIVE QUESTIONS

1. Which of these could I deliver **tomorrow** if someone paid me today?
2. Which of these can I do **entirely from a phone**?
3. Which of these have I already done for **someone else, for free**?
4. Which of these would I still be willing to do **in month three**, when it stops being new?
5. Which of these produces something a buyer can **see, hold or print**?

Answers four and five eliminate most options. Question four matters because the most common failure is choosing a service that bores you, then quietly stopping after six weeks.

The One-Skill, One-Buyer, One-Problem Rule

For your first ninety days, your entire offer is one skill, sold to one type of buyer, solving one specific problem.

THE RULE

`ONE skill + ONE buyer + ONE problem`

Not five skills, not "all businesses", not "whatever you need". Narrow enough that a stranger can repeat your offer back to you after hearing it once.

Narrowing feels like losing opportunities. It does the opposite. When you send thirty messages to the same type of buyer about the same problem, three things happen that never happen with a scattered offer. Your messages get faster to write, because you already know their situation. Your samples look relevant, because they are about their exact business. And your name starts to circulate inside that one community, which is how referrals begin.

You can widen later. After three or four clients in one niche, widening is straightforward because you now have proof. Before the first client, widening is only noise.

Ten Realistic Service Niches

These ten are chosen because they need no licence, no office, no team, and can be delivered from a phone. Example prices are illustrative only.

SERVICE	WHO BUYS IT	WHAT THEY GET	EXAMPLE PRICE
Google Business Profile setup and clean-up	Shops, clinics, salons and restaurants with no listing, or a listing with wrong hours	Correct name, category, hours, location, photos and a first set of replies to reviews	2,500–$120
Menu and price-list design	Cafes and restaurants	A printable, priced menu plus a phone-friendly version	1,500–$19
Social page management (writing and scheduling)	Retail shops that post irregularly	Twelve posts a month, written and queued, plus short replies to comments	3,000–$35/month

SERVICE	WHO BUYS IT	WHAT THEY GET	EXAMPLE PRICE
Product photo clean-up	Clothing, cosmetics and phone-accessory sellers	Clean backgrounds, straight crops, consistent lighting across a batch of 20 photos	150–$2/photo

SERVICE	WHO BUYS IT	WHAT THEY GET	EXAMPLE PRICE
Short-video editing for social	Gyms, salons, tour operators, event organisers	Edited 30 to 60 second clips with captions, from footage the client sends	500–$9/clip

SERVICE	WHO BUYS IT	WHAT THEY GET	EXAMPLE PRICE
the local language to English translation and proofreading	Importers, exporters, NGOs, small manufacturers	Accurate translated text for labels, brochures, forms or a website	250–$3/page
CV and professional profile writing	Job seekers and diaspora family members	A rewritten CV, a matching cover letter and a short profile paragraph	800–$12
Simple bookkeeping sheet setup	Small shops tracking money in a notebook	A Google Sheet that records daily sales and expenses and totals the month	2,000–$28 + monthly upkeep
Data entry and list building	Sales teams, event organisers, researchers	A clean, checked spreadsheet of names, phone numbers, categories and locations	1,000–$16/500 rows
Listing and itinerary content for tourism businesses	Guesthouses, tour operators and transport providers	Written descriptions, photo order and a day-by-day itinerary page	3,000–$8,000

Example prices only, current as of September 2026, for teaching purposes. They are not market rates and not a quote. Adjust to your city, your proof and your client. Where you are outside your city, expect the lower end of each range until you have three references.

WHY THESE TEN

Every one of them is **phone-capable, text-first where possible, and provable without clients**. You can build a sample for any of them this week, without permission and without a customer. That combination is what makes them usable by a beginner rather than aspirational.

Notice what is missing: no "build an app", no "run ad campaigns", no "manage a marketplace". Three separate studies and reports in this pack point the same way — over half of local e-commerce platforms earn under USD 10,000 a year, and more than 80% of federal business licences issued went dormant during 2025. **Most local small businesses are not durable advertisers.** Sell them something small, concrete and finished.

The Eight-Factor Opportunity Score

Take your top three service ideas and score each from 1 to 5 on all eight factors. Maximum 40.

FACTOR	SCORE 1 MEANS	SCORE 5 MEANS
Speed to learn	Months of study before I can deliver	I can deliver a basic version this week
Phone-capable	Needs a laptop and good bandwidth	Fully doable on a phone, offline if needed

FACTOR	SCORE 1 MEANS	SCORE 5 MEANS
Existing skill	I would be starting from zero	I have already done this for someone

FACTOR	SCORE 1 MEANS	SCORE 5 MEANS
Reachable buyers	I do not know where these buyers are	I can name 20 of them today, with contact routes

FACTOR	SCORE 1 MEANS	SCORE 5 MEANS
Visible local demand	I have never seen anyone buy this here	I can point to businesses clearly needing it now
Proof possible without clients	The work cannot be shown without a real client	I can build a labelled sample in one day
Delivery speed	Each project takes weeks	Each project finishes in one to four days
Price ceiling	The market pays a few hundred dollars, once	Clients pay thousands, and some keep paying monthly

Idea A — total / 40 .....

Idea B — total / 40 .....

Idea C — total / 40 .....

— **30–40:** start here. This is your service for the next 90 days.

— **22–29:** viable, but pick it only if the winner above it feels wrong to you.

— **Below 22:** do not build a business on it yet. Keep it as a second service for later.

SCORING HONESTLY

Most people score their favourite idea highest. Guard against that by scoring **"Reachable buyers"** first and hardest. If you cannot write down twenty named buyers with a contact route, the idea scores 1 or 2 on that factor no matter how much you like it, because a service nobody can be reached about does not produce a client.

Your Positioning Sentence

Write it now, by hand, and keep it where you can see it. Every message you send for the next ninety days starts from this sentence.

COPY-READY: POSITIONING SENTENCE TEMPLATE

I help [buyer type] in [place or market] get [specific result] by [your service], usually in [timeframe].

Filled example — fictional: I help cafes and restaurants in a regional city get a clean, priced, printable menu by redesigning their menu and price list, usually in four days.

You will use this sentence in your profile headline, the first line of every outreach message, your portfolio cover page and your invoice footer. Consistency is what makes a small service feel like a real business.

Section 02 checklist

- [ ] I have written three skills and the evidence that each one is real.
- [ ] I have scored three service ideas with the eight-factor method.
- [ ] I have chosen one service, and I can name twenty buyers for it.
- [ ] I have written my positioning sentence and saved it.
- [ ] I have told myself out loud that I will not offer five services for ninety days.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

03

SECTION THREE

Your Profile: Sell the Outcome, Not the CV

How to write a profile that reads like an offer, with five copy-ready bio versions for local and international buyers, a headline formula, photo and skills guidance, and the exact email signature that makes a beginner look organised.

01 A profile is not a CV

02 What a buyer reads first, in order

03 The headline formula

04 Five copy-ready bios: one line, short, full, local, international

05 Photo, skills list and the opener paragraph

06 Professional email setup and the exact signature

Your profile is not a description of you. It is an answer to one question the buyer is asking silently: *can this person do my job without creating problems for me?*

Most beginner profiles answer a different question — "what have I studied?" — which is why they get read and ignored. This section rewrites yours so that it answers the buyer's real question in the first eight seconds.

03. A Profile Is Not a CV

EXPLAIN A CV lists your history and ends with a hope. A profile states your offer and ends with a next step. On a freelancing platform, in a LinkedIn headline, or in the first message you send, the buyer is not hiring your past. They are buying a result they can picture.

SHOW **CV voice:** "Recent graduate in Business Administration from [university]. Hardworking, fast learner, good with computers. Looking for opportunities to grow."

Profile voice: "I build simple sales and expense sheets for small shops, so the owner knows what the month actually made. Delivered in three days. Sheet works on a phone."

The second one sells. The first one asks.

DO Rewrite your profile in four blocks: outcome, who for, what you deliver, next step. Nothing before those four blocks.

CHECK Read your profile aloud. If the word "I" appears more often than the word "you" or the buyer's own vocabulary, rewrite it.

What a buyer reads first, in order

ORDER	WHAT THEY LOOK AT	TIME SPENT	WHAT DECIDES IT
1	Your photo	Under 2 seconds	Is this a real person who looks professional?
2	Your headline or first line	2–4 seconds	Do they do the thing I need?
3	Your sample or portfolio link	10–30 seconds	Can I see the quality before I talk to them?
4	Your price or price range	5 seconds	Is this within what I expected to spend?
5	Your history and reviews	Only if the first four worked	Has anyone else taken this risk already?

Almost every beginner spends their effort on number five, which is the only item that does not exist yet, and neglects one to four, which are entirely under their control today.

The Headline Formula

COPY-READY: HEADLINE FORMULA

[What you do] for [who] — [outcome] in [timeframe].

Filled examples — fictional:

Menu and price-list design for cafes and restaurants — a printable, priced menu in four days.

Bookkeeping sheets for small shops — daily sales and expenses that total themselves every month.

the local language to English translation for importers — accurate label and packaging text, delivered in 48 hours.

Keep the headline under 90 characters. It goes on your platform profile, your LinkedIn headline, your Telegram bio line, and the first line of your email signature.

Five Copy-Ready Bios

Write all five. They are used in different places, and having them ready means you never improvise under pressure.

1. The one-line bio

COPY-READY: ONE-LINE BIO

I [do what] for [who], so they get [result] — usually in [time]. Based in [city], your country.

2. The short bio (about 60 words)

COPY-READY: SHORT BIO

I am [first name], a [service] based in [city], your country. I work with [buyer type] who need [the problem you solve].

My work is simple to review: you send [what they send], I deliver [exact deliverable] within [timeframe], and [number] rounds of changes are included.

See three sample projects here: [portfolio link]

3. The full bio (about 150 words)

COPY-READY: FULL BIO

I am [first name]. I help [buyer type] get [specific outcome].

What I do. [One paragraph describing the work in plain language, no jargon.]

Who I do it for. [Buyer type, and the situation they are usually in when they contact me.]

What you get. [Exact deliverable, file format, and timeframe.]

How I work. I confirm the scope in writing before starting. You get a written update every [two days]. Files are delivered compressed, with a share link as a backup. [Two] rounds of revisions are included.

Where I am. [City], your country, GMT+3. I work with clients in other time zones and I answer messages within [12 hours].

Three sample projects: [portfolio link]

4. The local local client version

A local owner does not care about time zones. They care whether you can be reached, whether you will finish, and whether they can meet you. Lead with those.

COPY-READY: LOCAL CLIENT BIO

Selam! I am [first name], based in [city / district / area]. I [service] for [business type].

For example: [one specific thing you did for someone, even unpaid].

I can come to your shop to collect what I need, or you can send it on Telegram. Most jobs are finished in [three] days, and I show you a draft before the final version so nothing is a surprise.

Price for a standard job: [amount] USD. Payment by a mobile wallet or bank transfer, half before and half on delivery.

Phone: [number]. Telegram: [handle].

5. The international client version

A foreign buyer's first worry is whether you will disappear. Answer reliability, time zone and file delivery before anything else.

COPY-READY: INTERNATIONAL CLIENT BIO

I am [first name], a [service] working from [city], your country (GMT+3). I help [buyer type] with [specific deliverable].

How I work with international clients. I confirm the scope in writing before starting. I send a written progress update every [two days], so you always know where the work stands. I answer messages within [12 hours] and I am available for calls between [time] and [time] your time.

Files. Deliveries are compressed and sent as a direct file plus a share link, so a slow connection on either side never blocks the work.

Samples. Three labelled sample projects: [link]. Sample 1 is [type], sample 2 is [type], sample 3 is [type].

Payment is by [agreed route] — I confirm the route with you in writing before work begins.

NEVER IN A BIO

Do not write "expert", "professional", "10 years of experience" or anything else you cannot evidence. Do not name a real company as a client unless they actually paid you or gave you written permission to say so. Do not write a review of yourself. Buyers check, and one false claim costs you every future message you send in that community.

Photo, Skills and the Opener

Your profile photo

— Face clearly visible, taken in daylight, near a window or outdoors in shade.

— Plain background: a wall works better than a street or a room.

— Shoulders up, camera at eye level, looking at the lens.

— One colour of clothing that contrasts with the wall.

— No sunglasses, no hat covering your face, no group photo cropped down to you, no logo, no cartoon.

— Save it as a square image and use the same photo on every platform. Recognition is worth more than novelty.

A phone camera, a window and a friend who counts to three is enough. Do not delay your start waiting for a professional photographer.

Your skills list

List between five and eight items, all related to the one service you chose. Related does not mean identical: if you sell menu design, list layout, print-ready file preparation, photo retouching, price-list formatting and revision handling. Everything on the list should be something a buyer of that service would recognise as part of the job.

THE TEST

If a skill on your list would never appear in a message from a buyer, delete it. "Hardworking", "fast learner" and "team player" are not skills a buyer searches for. "Print-ready PDF", "the local language proofreading" and "Google Sheets formulas" are.

The opener paragraph

Wherever a profile allows a description, open with this three-part structure. It takes ninety seconds to write and it outperforms every clever introduction.

COPY-READY: OPENER PARAGRAPH

What I do: [one sentence, in the buyer's words].

Who I do it for: [buyer type and their situation].

What you get: [exact deliverable, format, timeframe].

Professional Email Setup

An address like `coolkid_1998@example.com` costs you replies. A first name and last name costs nothing and buys credibility. Create one today and use it for every client conversation.

DO	DO NOT
`firstname.lastname@` provider	Nicknames, numbers, years of birth
Display name set to your real full name	Display names like "King", "Boss" or a shop name
A photo and a one-line bio in the account settings	Blank profiles with no photo
Reply within 12 hours, even if only to say when you will answer properly	Leaving a client message unread for three days

COPY-READY: EXACT EMAIL SIGNATURE

[Full name]
[Service] for [buyer type]
[+251 phone number] · [email address]
Telegram: [@handle] · Portfolio: [link]
[City], your country · GMT+3

Five lines, no images, no coloured background. Plain text signatures load instantly on a slow connection and look the same in every email client, which matters when the client is reading on a phone.

Translation: when writing to a client, make your name, your service and your phone number clear. Open with a greeting, describe the work briefly, and close politely.

Section 03 checklist

- [ ] My headline follows the formula and is under 90 characters.
- [ ] I have written all five bios and saved them where I can copy them in seconds.
- [ ] My photo is a clear, square, daylight headshot used on every platform.
- [ ] My skills list contains five to eight items that a buyer would recognise.
- [ ] My professional email address exists and my signature is set up.
- [ ] A stranger could read my profile and say what I sell, to whom, and for how long.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

04

SECTION FOUR

A Portfolio Without Clients

How to manufacture real proof before you have a single customer: three fully worked sample projects, the spec-piece workflow, a one-page PDF portfolio you can build for free, where to host it, and the message that asks permission before you publish.

01 Why a labelled sample beats an empty portfolio

02 Three sample projects, worked end to end

03 The spec-piece workflow, with the permission rule

04 Building the one-page PDF portfolio for free

05 Where to host it, and how to present it from a phone

06 The "may I use this as a sample?" message

Every beginner hits the same wall: nobody will hire you without samples, and you cannot make samples without a client. The wall is not real. It exists because people assume a sample has to come from paid work.

A labelled sample — made for a real business, with permission, marked clearly as unsolicited — does almost the same job as paid work. This section builds three of them, step by step, in a way that is honest and legally safe.

04. Why a Labelled Sample Beats an Empty Portfolio

When a buyer opens your portfolio, they are answering one question: *can this person produce the thing I need?* They are not checking whether you were paid. Being paid is evidence, but it is not the only evidence.

What a sample proves

That you can produce the deliverable, that you understand the buyer's business, that you can follow a format, and that you finish things. Four of the five things a client worries about.

What a sample does not prove

That you have worked with a paying customer before, that you met a real deadline under pressure, and that you handle revisions well. Say so honestly if asked, and offset it with your revision policy and your scope document.

THE LABELLING RULE IS NOT OPTIONAL

Every sample you publish must carry the words **"Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration. Not a client project."** on the image, in the file name, and in the caption.

Two reasons. First, honesty: presenting unsolicited work as paid client work is a lie, and it breaks the moment someone asks a follow-up question. Second, self-interest: a clearly labelled sample tells the business owner "this person already did work for me, for free, without being asked", which is a strong and true signal of interest.

Three Sample Projects, Worked End to End

Build three, in three different formats, so a buyer can see range without seeing clutter. Each one takes one day. Use the same three for every prospect in your niche.

Sample project A — the redesigned menu

EXAMPLE SCENARIO — FICTIONAL

Business: the commercial district Beans Cafe, a fictional 14-seat cafe. **Problem:** their Google Maps photos show a laminated menu from 2023 with prices crossed out in pen and no vegetarian section.

1. **Collect the raw material**

   Open Google Maps, find a cafe near you with a photographed menu. Screenshot the menu pages. Note the current prices from the photos. Do not contact them yet.

2. **Rebuild it properly**

   In a free design tool on your phone, recreate one page: correct prices, categories in a sensible order, a vegetarian marker, and a clear heading with the cafe name. Two fonts maximum. One accent colour.

1. **Make it buyable**

   Export two files: the full menu as a PDF, and a single square image of the first page for sending on Telegram or WhatsApp. Keep the PDF under 2 MB.

1. **Label it and record it**

   Name the file `Sample-Menu-YourName.pdf`. Put the sample label on the bottom of the page. Write one sentence in your tracker: what the original problem was, and what you changed.

Sample project B — the 12-post content calendar

EXAMPLE SCENARIO — FICTIONAL

Business: Lakeview Style House, a fictional clothing shop. **Problem:** their Facebook page has three posts in the last four months, all of them the same photo with different text.

1. **Write the twelve posts**

   In Google Docs, write twelve short posts: three product posts, three behind-the-scenes posts, two customer-question posts, two price or offer posts, one holiday or event post, one community post. Each post is under 60 words, in the language the shop actually posts in.

2. **Add the practical column**

   Turn it into a table with four columns: date, post text, what image to use, and the one action the reader should take. This column structure is what makes it look like a service rather than a document.

3. **Deliver it as a document**

   Export as PDF and also keep the Google Doc link. The Doc proves you can work in the client's own tools; the PDF proves you finish things.

4. **Label it and record it**

   File name `Sample-ContentPlan-YourName.pdf`. In your tracker, note the posting gap you found and how many posts you produced.

Sample project C — the tourism listing rewrite

EXAMPLE SCENARIO — FICTIONAL

Business: Highland Tour Link, a fictional two-person tour operator. **Problem:** their listing describes a four-day trip in one dense paragraph, with no day-by-day detail and no prices.

1. **Rewrite the description**

   Three short paragraphs: who the trip suits, what makes it different, and what is included. Plain English. No words a visitor would need to look up.

2. **Build the day-by-day table**

   Four rows, one per day: where they go, what they see, where they sleep, what is included. Add an "example price" row clearly marked as an example.

1. **Suggest the photo order**

   List the six photos the listing should open with, in order, with one line each explaining why. This costs you nothing and makes the sample look like advice rather than decoration.

1. **Label it and record it**

   File name `Sample-TourListing-YourName.pdf`. Note in your tracker the before-and-after word count.

The Spec-Piece Workflow

A spec piece is work you produce for a real business, unasked, before any conversation. It is the single most effective opening move for a beginner, and it carries one hard rule.

1. **Choose a real, local, small business**

   Use Google Maps. Search your niche in your city. Pick a business with an obvious, fixable problem you can see in public: a stale menu, no prices, three posts in four months, a wrong phone number. Never a large company with a marketing department.

2. **Make the free sample**

   Keep it small: one menu page, one week of posts, one rewritten listing. Do not do the whole job. A sample that gives away everything removes the reason to hire you.

3. **Label it before you send it anywhere**

   Sample label on the work, in the file name, and in the message. No exceptions, even if you are certain it will never be published.

4. **Send it with permission framed as a question**

   Send the sample privately, with the message below, asking permission before you publish it anywhere. Asking first turns a possible irritation into a small compliment.

5. **Publish only what is permitted**

   If they say yes, publish it with the label. If they say no, keep it in your private portfolio and show it to other prospects, still labelled. If they do not reply, do not publish their name or logo at all.

6. **Remove anything on request, immediately**

   If a business asks you to take a sample down, take it down the same day and thank them. Reputation travels fast in a small market.

COPY-READY: PERMISSION MESSAGE FOR A SAMPLE

Selam [business name],

My name is [your name]. I [service] for [business type] in [city].

I noticed [one specific, factual observation — e.g. your Google listing shows a menu photo from 2023 with no prices]. I made one page as a free sample to show what a cleaned-up version could look like. It is attached, and it is marked as a sample.

Two questions, and you can say no to both:

1. May I show this sample to other businesses as an example of my work, with your name removed?
2. Would you like me to finish the full [menu / plan / listing]? It takes [three] days and costs [amount] USD.

If you would rather I did not use it anywhere, tell me and I will delete it today. No problem at all.

Thank you for your time,
[your name] · [phone]

DO NOT DO THIS

Do not use a real business logo as if it were your client. Do not copy a photographer's image and present it as your own design. Do not take a real company's website, rebuild it and claim you built the original. Do not put a real business name on a "testimonial". All four are the fastest way to lose a market that talks to itself.

The One-Page PDF Portfolio

One page. Not twelve. A cautious buyer will not scroll through a long document on a phone, and a long document hides your best work on page seven.

What goes on the page

POSITION	CONTENT	WHY
Top	Your name, your headline formula, your city and your phone number	Instant identification and instant contact
Upper middle	Three sample images or screenshots, one per project, each with a two-line caption: the problem, then what you did	Proof before explanation
Lower middle	What you deliver, in three bullets, with your timeframe and price range	Removes the "how much" guesswork
Bottom	The sample label, your email, and one line: "Full samples available on request."	Honesty plus a reason to reply

How to build it free

— **On a phone:** build the page in Google Docs using a table for the layout, insert your three images, then use Share and Export to PDF. It will not look like a design agency made it, and that is fine — it will look organised.

— **On a borrowed laptop:** the same Google Docs method, or a free design tool with a single-page template. Fifteen minutes, not two hours.

— **Keep it under 3 MB.** Compress images before inserting. A portfolio that will not download is worse than no portfolio.
— **Name the file properly:** `YourName-Service-Portfolio.pdf`. Not `final-final2.pdf`.

Where to host it for free

OPTION	BEST FOR	WATCH OUT FOR
Google Drive link, view-only	Almost everything. Works from a phone, shares into email and Telegram	Set sharing to "anyone with the link can view", and test it in a private browsing window before you send it
Telegram channel you own	Fast repeat sharing, and clients who prefer Telegram	Post the PDF as a file, not as screenshots with no captions
A one-page website	Later, when a foreign client asks for a link that is not a Drive folder	Do not build a website before your first client. It is a two-week detour that produces no messages
Your platform profile portfolio tab	Freelancing platforms, if you register on one	Re-upload the images rather than linking out; some platforms hide external links

PRESENTING IT FROM A PHONE

When a client asks to see your work in a chat, do not send a Drive link and wait. Send **one image** first — the strongest sample, exported as a square image under 500 KB — then the PDF, then the link. Three steps, in that order.

If you are meeting in person, have the PDF open and offline on your phone, and a saved screenshot of the first page in your gallery. Do not rely on the client's wi-fi to show your own work.

Section 04 checklist

- [ ] I have built three sample projects, each in a different format.
- [ ] Every sample carries the label "Sample — created by [my name] for demonstration. Not a client project."
- [ ] My one-page PDF portfolio exists, is under 3 MB, and has a clean file name.
- [ ] My Drive link is set to view-only and I have tested it in a private window.
- [ ] I have the permission message saved and ready to send.
- [ ] I can show my portfolio from my phone without using the client's internet.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

05

SECTION FIVE

Finding Work: Four Channels That Actually Produce Buyers

The exact mechanics of the four channels open to an local freelancer today — direct local outreach, local and diaspora Telegram and Facebook communities, LinkedIn for B2B prospecting, and international freelancing platforms — plus the prospect list structure that keeps all of it organised in one sheet.

01 How small the reachable market really is

02 Channel 1: direct outreach to small local businesses

03 Channel 2: Telegram and Facebook communities

04 Channel 3: LinkedIn for B2B prospecting

05 Channel 4: international freelancing platforms, with the eligibility warning

06 The prospect list: ten columns in one Google Sheet

There is no shortage of advice about where to find clients. There is a shortage of exact instructions. This section gives you the four channels that work for an local beginner today, with the clicks, the search terms, the sheet columns and the etiquette for each one.

Read the first channel carefully even if you plan to work internationally. Local buyers are the fastest route to your first payment, and a local payment is what proves to you that this works.

05. How Small the Reachable Market Really Is

Start with the numbers, because they change your channel strategy immediately.

29.5 m	107 m	9.80 m
INTERNET USERS — 21.7% OF THE POPULATION	PEOPLE OFFLINE — 78.3%	SOCIAL MEDIA IDENTITIES — 7.2% OF THE POPULATION

Source: DataReportal Digital 2026: your country. Figures are current as of September 2026.

Two of those numbers should shape how you prospect. First, social media identities where you live are around **9.80 million**, and Facebook's ad reach is the same figure — roughly 13.2% of adults aged 18 and over. Instagram reach is around **1.55 million**. Second, smartphone ownership is about **15% of the population**, and it is uneven: around 6% for women against 18% for men, according to GSMA's Mobile Gender Gap work reported in the local press.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PRACTICE

Do not plan a business around "everyone is online". A large share of the small local businesses you walk past are not reachable by email, Instagram or a platform message, and some are not reachable by any digital channel at all.

That is not a reason to stop. It is a reason to use **phone calls, Telegram and in-person visits** where they apply, and to treat email and platforms as the channel for the smaller, more digital segment — plus foreign buyers, who are entirely reachable online.

It also means an underrated advantage: because so few businesses here are used to being approached well, a clear, specific, polite message stands out more than it would in a crowded market.

Channel 1 — Direct Outreach to local Businesses

This is the channel with the highest chance of producing your first payment, and the one most beginners skip because it involves talking to people nearby.

The exact mechanics, step by step

1. **Open Google Maps and search your niche in your city**

   Search "cafe", "restaurant", "salon", "gym", "guest house", "clinic", "boutique" — whichever matches the service you chose in section 02. Add your area name. Work through the first 20 results.

1. **Inspect each one for about two minutes**

   Check four things: opening hours (are they correct?), photos (how old do they look?), phone number (does it look current?), and their Instagram or Facebook page if linked. Then look at the last ten posts on that page.

1. **Write one specific improvement per business**

   Not "needs better marketing" but "menu photos from 2023, no prices shown, last post four months ago". One line. This line is the whole reason your message will get read.

1. **Put it in your prospect sheet with a contact route**

   Business name, type, area, phone number if listed, Instagram handle if present, and your one-line observation. Five minutes per business, twenty businesses per hour of work.

2. **Make one sample for the best three, then message them**

   Use the spec-piece method from section 04. Send the sample to those three today. Send a plain message, without a sample, to the rest.

WHERE ELSE TO LOOK WHEN GOOGLE MAPS RUNS DRY

a local classifieds site (`jiji.com.et`) carries live, dollars-priced classifieds across Addis sub-cities and beyond, including Services and Business & Industry. It shows you who is actively selling right now.

an online business directory has about 30 categories with counts and a 14-city filter — for example Import & Export listed at 2,784 entries, Professional Services at 2,058, Factories at 1,186, Construction at 956, and Restaurants & Cafes at 257. The city filter is what makes it useful outside Addis.

an online business directory's directory states more than 10,000 companies, and it has a free "Add your Business" feature — useful for understanding how businesses describe themselves.

your chamber of commerce lists around 12 chambers and about 6 associations with phone numbers. That is not a prospect list; it is a route to a whole member base at once. One polite call to a sector association can put your offer in front of fifty businesses.

The local Yellow Pages is dead as a channel — its Play Store listing has been delisted. Do not build a prospecting plan on it.

SET YOUR EXPECTATIONS ON DURABILITY

More than **80% of federal business licences issued went dormant during 2025**, according to reporting by The Reporter your country. Most local small businesses are not durable advertisers, and some of the businesses you contact this month will not exist next year.

This is why you do not sell a twelve-month contract to a business you have never worked with. Sell one small, finished job. If they pay and the work is good, sell the next one.

Channel 2 — Telegram and Facebook Communities

Telegram is where a large part of local business conversation actually happens, and it is light on data. It is also the channel where beginners get removed from groups fastest, because they arrive and immediately post an advertisement.

The rule: contribute before you pitch

01 Join ten relevant groups

Search Telegram for your niche plus your city: business owners, cafe and restaurant owners, real estate agents, importers, job boards for your skill. Join ten. Read for a week before posting anything.

02 Answer three questions before you ask one

In every group, someone asks a question you can answer — a formatting problem, a translation, a supplier question, a formula in Sheets. Answer it properly, in public, with no pitch attached. That answer is your advertisement.

03 Put the offer in your profile, not the chat

Your Telegram bio and profile name carry your headline formula. When someone reads a good answer from you and taps your name, the offer is right there. No group rules are broken.

04 Send the pitch privately, and only when invited

If someone replies to your answer with interest, or the group rules allow a weekly promotion thread, use it. Otherwise send a direct message. Never broadcast a pitch to a group that did not ask for it.

Group etiquette that keeps you in the room

- Read the pinned rules before your first message. Many groups state the exact day and format allowed for promotion.
- Never post the same message in five groups in one hour. Administrators talk to each other, and shared ban lists exist.
- Do not add strangers to a group they did not ask to join. This is the single fastest way to be reported.
- Never ask for work in a group where you have never contributed. It reads as taking, not offering.
- When you do win a client through a group, thank the group publicly and share what you learned — not what you earned.

DIASPORA GROUPS ARE A REAL CHANNEL, WITH A CAVEAT

local diaspora Facebook groups and Telegram channels contain people who own businesses here, fund family projects here, and need work done in the local language while sitting in Dubai, Toronto or Washington. They are often the most reachable foreign clients, because there is no language or trust barrier to cross.

The caveat is payment. A diaspora client is a foreign client for payment purposes, so section 08 applies: agree the route in writing before work starts.

Channel 3 — LinkedIn for B2B Prospecting

LinkedIn is the smallest of the big platforms where you live and the most useful for one specific job: reaching companies rather than individuals.

1.80 m	+38.5%	1.55 m
LOCAL LINKEDIN MEMBERS	YEAR-ON-YEAR GROWTH	INSTAGRAM REACH, FOR COMPARISON

Source: DataReportal Digital 2026: your country. 1.80 million members, up 38.5% year on year. Figures current as of September 2026.

That growth matters. A channel growing at that rate has more new accounts and fewer entrenched suppliers than a mature one, which is exactly the condition a beginner needs.

How to use it, mechanically

1. **Build the profile first, then prospect**
   Use the international bio from section 03 as your About section, the headline formula as your headline, and a square headshot. Nobody accepts a connection request from a blank profile.
2. **Search by company and by role, not by keyword**
   Search the companies you already know hire for your service — hotels, tour operators, clinics, logistics firms, banks, NGOs, tech companies. Then look at who inside them holds the relevant job title.
3. **Send a connection request with a short note**
   Under 300 characters, no pitch. "Selam [name] — I work on [service] for [sector] where you live. Following your posts on [topic]. Happy to connect."
4. **Engage for a week before you pitch**
   Comment on two or three of their posts, with something substantive rather than "Great post". Then send the outreach message from section 06. The reply rate difference between pitching cold and pitching after a week of visible engagement is large.
5. **Move the conversation off LinkedIn quickly**
   Once they reply with interest, ask for email or a call. LinkedIn messaging is a poor place to send files, and a client who moves to email is far more likely to become a paying client.

TWO LINKEDIN HABITS THAT WORK FOR LOCALS SPECIFICALLY

Post your work, not your opinions. One post a week showing a before-and-after of a sample project reaches more useful people than daily commentary. Attach the image directly, not a link.

Use both languages in one post. A short English line followed by a short the local language line doubles who can act on it, and it signals clearly which market you serve.

Channel 4 — International Freelancing Platforms

Platforms are where most beginners look first and where most beginners get discouraged first. They are worth using, but only with an accurate understanding of how they work for someone where you live.

READ THIS BEFORE YOU SPEND A WEEK ON ANY PLATFORM

Country eligibility for registration and country eligibility for payouts are two different things, and both vary by platform and by individual account. A platform may accept your sign-up and still have no payout route that works for a resident of a country with limited payment access.

This course will not tell you which platforms accept your country, because that list changes, the answers are inconsistent between platforms, and a course printed in September 2026 cannot be trusted on it in March 2027. **You must verify current registration eligibility and current payout availability yourself, on the platform's own official help pages, before you invest time in it.**

Then the hard rules, which are not negotiable:

— **Never misrepresent your country.** Not in sign-up, not in your profile, not in a tax form.

— **Never use a VPN to bypass a country restriction.** That is circumventing the platform's own rules.

— **Never rent, buy or borrow an account** or someone else's identity documents.

Accounts closed for these reasons lose the balance inside them. There is no appeal that gets your money back.

How to use platforms without wasting a month

STEP	WHAT YOU DO	TIME BUDGET
1	Pick **one** platform. Check its official help pages for both registration eligibility and payout methods available where you live.	45 minutes
2	If either answer is no or unclear, stop. Do not register on five platforms hoping one works.	5 minutes
3	If both are workable, complete the profile fully: photo, headline, About, skills, portfolio images, and your price for a small job.	2 hours
4	Send 10 tailored proposals. Not 50 copied ones. Each proposal references the specific job post.	3 hours
5	Assess honestly after 10. Replies? Interviews? If nothing at all, the problem is usually the proposal, not the platform — reread section 06.	30 minutes

THE HONEST ECONOMICS OF PLATFORM WORK

Platforms put you in a global auction. On price, you cannot win it, and you should not try. What you can win is the job where the buyer needs something specific and fast — a translation into the local language, a document formatted by tomorrow, a list built from a country with limited payment accessn sources, a small design job nobody wants.

Those jobs pay less than the headline rates you see quoted, and the competition on the big generic categories is severe. Treat platforms as **one of four channels**, expect a lower reply rate than direct outreach, and never let platform applications replace the five direct messages you send each day.

The Prospect List: Ten Columns, One Sheet

Build this in Google Sheets today. It works offline on a phone once opened, and it becomes the single record of your entire outreach business.

COLUMN	WHAT GOES IN IT	EXAMPLE
Business name	Exactly as listed publicly	Example scenario — fictional: the commercial district Beans Cafe
Type	Your niche category	Cafe
Area / city	Where they are	a regional city, Piazza area
Contact route	Phone, Instagram, Telegram, email, or "walk in"	Instagram DM + phone
One specific observation	The factual thing you noticed. This line powers your message.	Menu photos from 2023, no prices, last post 4 months ago
Offer angle	Which service and which package fits them	Standard menu package
Date contacted	The day you actually sent something. Empty means untouched.	2026-09-15
Follow-up due	Contacted date plus 4 days	2026-09-19
Status	New · Contacted · Follow-up 1 · Follow-up 2 · Replied · Quoted · Won · Lost · Dormant	Follow-up 1
Notes	What they said, what they need, when to try again	Owner interested, wants to see price for 2 pages

Business names in this table are fictional examples. Build the sheet with your own real research.

TARGET EXAMPLE — NOT A PREDICTION

```
20 prospects/week × 4 weeks = 80 prospects
80 × 2 follow-ups = 240 touches
```

Arithmetic, not a forecast. Most of these will produce nothing. That is normal, and the sheet is what tells you which ones are still alive.

NEVER TYPE A PHONE NUMBER YOU FOUND INTO A BULK-MESSAGING APP

Do not add prospects to a group, do not send the same message to 80 numbers from a bulk sender, and do not scrape numbers into a separate database. Beyond being ineffective, bulk messaging apps are heavily associated with fraud where you live, and a genuine business owner who receives one will block you rather than hire you.

Send individual messages, from your own number, with the business name at the top. That is slower and it works.

Section 05 checklist

- [ ] My prospect sheet exists with all ten columns.
- [ ] I have 20 named prospects with contact routes and one specific observation each.
- [ ] I have joined ten Telegram or Facebook groups and read the pinned rules in each.
- [ ] I have answered at least three questions in those groups with no pitch attached.

- [ ] My LinkedIn profile is complete, or I have written down why I am not using LinkedIn.

- [ ] I have checked one platform's official help pages for registration eligibility and payout availability where you live, and written down the date I checked.

- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

06

SECTION SIX

Proposals and Outreach: Ten Scripts You Can Use Today

Why most beginner proposals fail, the five-part structure that fixes them, and ten copy-ready scripts covering local and international cold outreach, platform proposals, three follow-ups, price questions, price objections, a rejection, and a job you are slightly under-qualified for.

01 Why most proposals fail

02 The five-part proposal structure

03 Scripts 1 and 2: cold outreach, local and international

04 Script 3: the platform proposal

05 Scripts 4 to 6: three follow-ups, and when to stop

06 Scripts 7 to 10: price, rejection, and stretching for a bigger job

A proposal is not a description of you. It is a small, low-risk decision that you are making straightforward for a busy person to say yes to.

The ten scripts in this section are the working parts of the course. Personalise every one — a copied script with no specific observation in it performs almost as badly as no message at all.

06. Why Most Proposals Fail

Beginners write proposals that answer the question *"what can I do?"*. Buyers are asking *"what will you do for me, and what could go wrong?"* Four specific failures follow from that gap.

THE FAILURE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE FIX
Talking about yourself first	"I am a hardworking graduate with skills in design, writing and translation."	Open with the buyer's situation, in one specific factual sentence.
No specific observation	A message that could have been sent to any business in the country.	Name one thing you actually saw. It proves you looked.
No clear deliverable	"I can help with your marketing."	Say exactly what you will hand over, in what format, by when.
No next step	The message ends with "let me know".	End with one specific question that can be answered in one word.

LENGTH

Under 120 words for a first message. Under 200 for a proposal on a platform. A busy owner reads on a phone, between customers, with one hand. If your first message requires scrolling, it will be closed.

The Five-Part Structure

Every message in this section follows the same five parts, in the same order. Learn the structure and you can write a new script for any situation.

1. **Observation**

   One factual thing you noticed about their business. Not a compliment. A fact: something missing, outdated, or done well that could be extended.

2. **Consequence**

   One line about what that costs them. Keep it modest and honest. "Customers searching for you see last year's prices." Not "you are losing millions."

3. **Deliverable**

   Exactly what you will produce, in what format, and how long it takes. One sentence.

1. **Proof**

   The sample you already made, or a link to a labelled sample. Attach it; do not describe it.

2. **One question**

   A question answerable in one word or one line. "Shall I send the full version?" Not "what are your thoughts?"

Scripts 1 and 2 — Cold Outreach

SCRIPT 1: COLD OUTREACH TO A LOCAL LOCAL BUSINESS

Selam [business name],

I saw your Google listing today — the menu photos are from [year] and the prices are not showing. Anyone searching for a place to eat in [area] sees those first.

I redesign menus and price lists for cafes and restaurants. I already rebuilt one page of yours as a free sample — it is attached and marked as a sample.

The full menu takes me [three] days and costs [amount] USD. You see a draft before I finish, and [two] rounds of changes are included.

Would you like me to send the full version so you can see it before deciding?

Thank you,
[your name] · [phone] · [portfolio link]

SCRIPT 2: COLD OUTREACH TO AN INTERNATIONAL CLIENT

Hello [first name],

I read your post about [specific thing they wrote or posted]. You mentioned [the problem they described] — that is the part I work on.

I am a [service] based where you live (GMT+3). I do [one specific deliverable] for [buyer type], usually in [timeframe].

Two examples of my work are here: [link]. Both are labelled samples, not client projects, so you know exactly what you are looking at.

How I work: written scope confirmed before I start, a written update every [two days], compressed files with a backup link, and I reply within [12] hours.

Would it help if I sent a short plan for [their specific task], with a fixed price, so you can compare it against your current option?

Best regards,
[your name]
[service] · [email] · [portfolio link]

WHY SCRIPT 2 OFFERS A PLAN INSTEAD OF ASKING FOR THE JOB

Asking a stranger for a job requires them to make a decision immediately. Offering to send a short plan asks them for something almost free, and it moves you from "unknown applicant" to "person who sent something useful". Most paid work starts with a document, not a yes.

Script 3 — The Platform Proposal

Platform proposals are read in a list of twenty identical ones. The first line is the only line guaranteed to be read, so it must name their job, not your skills.

SCRIPT 3: PLATFORM PROPOSAL

First line: You need [their exact deliverable] by [their deadline] — here is how I would do it.

Understanding: From your post, you have [what they have] and you need [what they need]. The part that usually causes trouble is [one specific risk in this type of job].

Plan: Day 1 — [step]. Day 2 — [step]. Day 3 — [delivery and revisions].

Relevant sample: [link] — sample [number] is the closest to your job. It is labelled as a sample, not client work.

Price: [amount] for the scope above. I can start [day].

Question: Is the deadline fixed, or is there room to deliver [alternative] instead?

Never copy the same platform proposal into ten job posts. A buyer who receives two identical proposals from the same person reports it, and some platforms restrict the account.

Scripts 4 to 6 — Follow-Ups, and When to Stop

Most replies come from the follow-up, not the first message. Most beginners never send one. The pattern is three touches, then stop.

TOUCH	WHEN	WHAT IT ADDS
First message	Day 0	The observation and the offer
Follow-up 1	Day 4	One new piece of value — a second sample, or an added detail
Follow-up 2	Day 11	A smaller ask, or a deadline that is real
Final follow-up	Day 25	A polite close with the door left open

SCRIPT 4: FOLLOW-UP 1 (DAY 4)

Selam [name], following up once on the menu sample I sent on [day].

I also rebuilt your [second item — e.g. the drinks page], since it had the same issue. That version is attached too.

If a full menu is more than you need right now, I can do only the [one page] for [smaller amount] USD. Would that be more useful?

Thank you,
[your name]

SCRIPT 5: FOLLOW-UP 2 (DAY 11)

Selam [name], one more note and then I will stop taking up your time.

I have [two] slots open this month and I am holding one until [date]. If you want the [deliverable] finished before [event or month end], that is the window.

If the timing is wrong, tell me when it is better and I will come back then instead.

Thank you,
[your name]

SCRIPT 6: FINAL FOLLOW-UP (DAY 25) — THE POLITE CLOSE

Selam [name],

I will close this for now so I am not filling your inbox. The sample stays with you — use it however you like, and if you would rather I removed it from my portfolio, say so and I will.

If [the problem] becomes a priority later, message me on [phone] and I will tell you honestly whether I am free and what it would cost.

Thank you for your time,
[your name]

THE STOP RULE

Three follow-ups, then stop. A fourth message is not persistence, it is a reason to be blocked. Move the prospect to **Dormant** in your sheet with a date three months out. Dormant prospects who receive one genuinely new message later — a new sample in their industry, a new service — sometimes convert. Repeated identical chasing does not.

Scripts 7 to 10 — Price, Rejection and Stretch

SCRIPT 7: REPLY TO "HOW MUCH?"

Thank you for asking. For [the exact deliverable], with [number] rounds of changes and delivery in [three] days, it is [amount] USD.

That covers: [item 1], [item 2], and [item 3].

Payment is [half] to start and [half] on delivery, by [a mobile wallet or bank transfer]. If you want a smaller version to start with, I can do [smaller scope] for [smaller amount] USD.

Which of the two would you prefer?

NEVER ANSWER "HOW MUCH?" WITH A RANGE

A range tells the buyer that your real price is the lower number. Give one number for one clearly described scope, then offer a second, smaller scope with its own single number. Two prices, two scopes, no range.

SCRIPT 8: REPLY TO "TOO EXPENSIVE"

I understand, and thank you for saying so directly.

Two options. First, we reduce the scope: **[smaller deliverable]** for **[lower amount]** USD. It is a smaller job and it costs less — the price per item stays the same, because the work per item stays the same.

Second, if **[amount]** is the ceiling, I can split it: **[half]** now for **[first part]**, and the rest next month if you are happy with it.

What I would rather not do is deliver the full scope for less, because that is the point where quality starts to slip and neither of us wants that.

Which option works better for you?

SCRIPT 9: REPLY TO "WE ALREADY HAVE SOMEONE"

That is good to hear — it means this matters to you.

I am not asking you to replace anyone. Two things I can be useful for: overflow when they are busy, and the **[specific task]** that usually gets pushed to the bottom of the list.

Can I check back in **[two months]**? And if the person you work with ever stops, you will have my sample already in your messages.

Thank you,
[your name]

SCRIPT 10: PROPOSAL FOR A JOB YOU ARE SLIGHTLY UNDER-QUALIFIED FOR

Hello **[name]**,

I want to be straightforward about one thing before anything else: I have not done **[the exact task]** at this scale before. Here is what I have done that is closest: **[specific, relevant piece of work]**, which is attached.

Because of that, here is how I would reduce your risk:

1. I deliver the first **[section / 25%]** within **[three]** days for you to review before I continue.
2. If that first part is not what you need, you pay nothing for it and we stop there.
3. The remaining **[75%]** is fixed at **[amount]**, agreed before I start.

Would you like me to do the first part so you can judge the work rather than my profile?

Best regards,
[your name]

WHY SCRIPT 10 WORKS

Buyers are not looking for the most qualified person. They are looking for the person who has thought hardest about reducing their risk. Admitting the gap and then designing a paid trial around it answers the buyer's real objection before they have to raise it — and it is the only honest way to stretch for a bigger job.

> Do not use this script to claim experience you do not have, and do not offer a free trial. A paid, small first stage is what keeps this honest and sustainable.

Translation: when they ask the price, give one number. If you say "we can also work for less", the price will always end up at the lowest figure. Describe the work clearly, name one price, and offer a second price only for a smaller scope.

Section 06 checklist

- [ ] All ten scripts are saved in my notes app or a Google Doc, ready to copy.
- [ ] I have personalised script 1 for at least five real businesses, each with a different observation.
- [ ] I have sent at least ten real messages in total.
- [ ] Every message ends with one question that can be answered in a word.
- [ ] My messages are under 120 words on the first contact.
- [ ] I have set follow-up dates in my prospect sheet for everyone I contacted.
- [ ] I have not sent the same text twice to two different businesses.

07

SECTION SEVEN

Objections, Negotiation and Closing

The eight objections beginners actually hear, an honest answer for each, how to quote without flinching, how to use anchoring and three-tier packages, when to walk away, how to ask for a deposit, and the exact words that close a deal.

01 The eight objections and what to say

02 Quoting a price without flinching

03 Anchoring, packages and the good/better/best trick

04 Asking for a deposit without losing the job

05 When to walk away

06 The exact closing words

Objections are not rejections. They are the buyer telling you what is still worrying them, which is useful information if you have an answer ready and dangerous if you do not.

This section gives you the answer for each of the eight you will actually hear, plus the pricing structure that makes most of them disappear before they are spoken.

07. The Eight Objections

Every one of these is a real sentence an local beginner hears in their first month. Read the reasoning, not only the reply — the reasoning is what lets you adapt the words.

1. "It is too expensive."

What they mean: either the number is genuinely above what they planned to spend, or they have not yet understood what they are buying.

What to say: "I understand. Two options: we can reduce the scope to [smaller deliverable] for [lower amount] USD, or we can split the payment across two months. What I would rather not do is the full job for less, because that is where quality slips."

What not to say: "Okay, I can do it for [half]." That sentence teaches the buyer that your first number was not real, and every future price you quote to them will be negotiated down.

2. "We already have someone."

What they mean: often true, sometimes a polite no.

What to say: "Good — that means it matters to you. I am not asking you to replace anyone. I am useful for overflow when they are busy, and for [the task that always gets delayed]. Can I check back in two months?"

Why it works: you have asked for nothing, you have planted a specific use case, and you have secured permission to make contact again. This objection converts into work more often than any other, six or twelve weeks later.

3. "Do a free test first."

What they mean: they are cautious about paying a stranger. It is a reasonable worry and a bad proposal.

What to say: "I have already done a free sample — it is attached, and it is yours to keep whether or not we work together. For the full job I do need payment, but I can structure it: [25%] for the first section, which you approve before I continue. If that first part is not right, we stop there."

> **THE FREE-WORK TRAP**
>
> Unpaid "tests" of a full project almost never convert into paid work, and a buyer who asks for a large free test before the first paid job is usually telling you how the whole relationship will go. One small labelled sample, sent proactively, is generous. A full unpaid project on request is a bad deal.

4. "Show me your previous clients."

What they mean: they want evidence and you appear to have none.

What to say: "I am new to freelancing, so I do not have paying clients yet — I would rather tell you that than invent one. What I do have is three labelled samples built for businesses like yours, including [the closest one]. I also confirm the scope in writing and include [two] rounds of changes, so the risk of a bad outcome is on me as much as on you."

Why it works: the honesty is disarming, and it is credible in a way a vague claim is not. Follow it immediately with the risk-reduction terms, so the conversation moves from your history to their project.

5. "We will pay you after we see results."

What they mean: they are trying to move all the risk onto you. Sometimes they mean it innocently; sometimes they intend never to pay.

What to say: "I understand wanting to see the work first. The way I usually handle that is [half] before I start and [half] on delivery, so you see the finished work before the final payment. Results that depend on how the work is used afterwards — sales, followers, customers — are not something I can guarantee, and I would rather say that now than argue about it later."

> **NEVER WORK ON PURE RESULTS-BASED PAYMENT AS A BEGINNER**
>
> You do not control the client's pricing, their staff, their location or their opening hours. Agreeing to be paid only on results means taking responsibility for things outside your control. This is different from a paid first stage, where the payment is small but real and tied to a deliverable you control.

6. "How do we know you will not disappear?"

What they mean: the trust problem, most common with foreign clients and first-time buyers.

What to say: "Fair question. Here is what reduces that risk: a written scope before we start, so we both know exactly what is owed; a written update every [two days], so you never wonder; delivery in stages, so you see progress early rather than at the end; and my full name, phone number and city in every message. If I stop communicating, you will know within two days, not two weeks."

7. "Someone else will do it for $3."

What they mean: they are comparing you to the cheapest visible option.

What to say: "That is a real option and it may suit you. What I include for [amount] is [item 1], [item 2] and [two] rounds of changes, delivered in [three] days, with the file in a format your printer accepts. If the $3 version arrives as a phone screenshot that cannot be printed, you will pay twice."

After saying it, stop talking. Do not discount. If they choose the cheaper option, wish them well and move to the next prospect. Some buyers are not your buyers, and that is normal.

8. "We have no budget right now. Try us next month."

What they mean: usually exactly that. Sometimes it is a polite no.

What to say:[specific date]

[lower amount]
[the main problem]

Then actually message them on that date. Most people who say this never hear from the freelancer again. Being the one who comes back on the agreed day is a genuine advantage.

Quoting a Price Without Flinching

Price is delivered, not discussed. Six rules cover almost every situation.

1. **Name one number for one scope.** No ranges. No "starting from". No "depending on".
2. **Say the number and then stop.** The silence after a price is the buyer thinking, not the buyer rejecting. Do not fill it with a discount.
3. **Put the deliverable next to the number, not after it.** "[amount] USD for [exact deliverable], delivered in [three] days."
4. **Never apologise for the price.** Not "sorry, it is a bit high, but..." — that sentence invites a negotiation you have already lost.
5. **Write it down.** Send the price in writing in the same message. A price said on a phone call and not repeated in writing is a price that will be disputed later.
6. **Charge the same number to similar clients.** Wildly different prices for the same work in the same community is how a reputation for unfairness starts.

Anchoring, Packages and Good/Better/Best

Most buyers cannot tell whether $3,200 is expensive, because they have nothing to compare it to. Your job is to give them the comparison.

Good	Better	Complete
$11 — one page, one round of changes, delivered in four days. Enough for a business that only needs the main page fixed.	**$3,200** — full set, printable PDF plus a phone version, two rounds of changes, three days. Most clients choose this one.	**$35** — everything in Better, plus photo clean-up and price updates for three months. Makes Better look reasonable.

Example scenario — fictional. Prices are illustrations of the package structure, not market rates.

HOW THE TRICK ACTUALLY WORKS

Present Complete first, then Better, then Good. The first number the buyer hears becomes the anchor, and Better looks moderate next to it. If you present Good first, everything after it feels expensive.

Never present more than three options. Four options create a decision the buyer postpones. Two options is fine for a small job; three is the maximum for anything larger.

And make sure every tier is a real product you would be content to deliver. A deliberately bad cheap tier is not a strategy — it is a way to end up doing bad work for someone who then tells other people about it.

Asking for a Deposit

Deposits protect you from the two most expensive outcomes: doing the work and never being paid, and doing the work twice because the brief changed.

SITUATION	ASK FOR	HOW TO SAY IT
New local client, job under $12	Full payment upfront	"For jobs this size I take payment before starting, so I can block the time."
New local client, job over $12	50% upfront, 50% on delivery	"Half to start and half when you have the finished file."
Existing local client, second or third job	Payment on delivery	"Same as last time — I will send the file and the invoice together."
New foreign client	Discuss the route first, then 50/50 or 100% for small jobs	"Before we start, let us confirm how payment will reach me. I will send the options that work from a country with limited payment access."

WHEN ASKING FOR A DEPOSIT FEELS AWKWARD

It feels awkward because you are worried they will say no. Say it plainly, in writing, as a normal business practice rather than a favour you are requesting:

"Payment is [half] to start and [half] on delivery, by [a mobile wallet or bank transfer]. Once that is sent I block [three] days for your job, and you will have the first draft on [day]."

A client who refuses any deposit on a first job, and offers no alternative, is telling you something. Take the smaller job instead, or take full payment for a smaller scope, or walk away.

When to Walk Away

Some jobs cost more than they pay. Walk away — politely, immediately — when you see any of these four signals.

— **They refuse to define the deliverable.** If they will not say what "finished" looks like after two attempts, the job has no end and no final payment.

— **They ask you to do the work first "to see if you are good".** A paid first stage is fine. Free full delivery is not.

— **They ask for something you consider dishonest.** Fake reviews, fake follower counts, invented testimonials, a fake address, copied work presented as original. Refuse. The reputational cost lands on you, not them.

— **They pay nothing upfront and demand an unrealistic deadline.** Both together usually means the deadline is already missed and you are being positioned to blame.

COPY-READY: THE POLITE WALK-AWAY

Thank you for explaining what you need. I do not think I am the right fit for this one, and I would rather say so now than deliver something that disappoints you.

I can recommend what to look for instead: **[one useful sentence of advice]**.

If something smaller comes up — **[your normal service]** — I would be glad to help with that.

Thank you,
[your name]

The Exact Words for Closing

Most deals are lost at the end, not the beginning, because beginners stop at "let me know" and never ask for the work.

MOMENT	SAY THIS
They show interest but have not decided	"Should I start on [Monday]?"
They have agreed the scope and price	"I will send the scope document today. Once the [deposit] is confirmed, I start [day] and you will have the first draft on [day]. Does that work?"
They go quiet after agreeing	"Confirming — are we still starting on [day]? If the timing has changed, that is fine, I only need to know before I block the time."
They want to negotiate scope down	"We can do that. The smaller version is [amount] USD and takes [two] days. Shall I send the scope for that one instead?"
They ask for a start date you cannot meet	"I can start on [date] instead, or deliver [partial] by your date and the rest after. Which is more useful?"

THE CLOSING RULE

Never end a client conversation without proposing the next concrete step. Not "let me know", not "I am available whenever". A date, a deliverable, a payment amount and a question.

If they say no, you have lost nothing except a message. If they say nothing, you have a follow-up date in your sheet. If they say yes, you have a client.

Section 07 checklist

- [ ] I have written my own answer to all eight objections and saved them.
- [ ] I have a written price list with three tiers and one number per tier.
- [ ] I know which deposit rule applies to each type of client.
- [ ] I have decided in advance what makes me walk away, so I do not decide it under pressure.
- [ ] Every conversation I have ends with a proposed date, deliverable and payment amount.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

08

SECTION EIGHT

Delivering Work and Getting Paid

The paperwork that makes a beginner look organised — scope document, onboarding message, kickoff checklist, progress updates, delivery message, revision policy and invoice wording — followed by the full payment chapter: local wallets and bank transfers, merchant gateways, the licensed remittance corridor for foreign clients, and the upgrade path to a service-exporter account.

01 The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

02 Local clients versus international clients

03 The legitimate routes, in order

04 What never to do

05 Tax and registration, honestly

Two things separate a freelancer who gets paid from one who gets argued with: a written scope before the work starts, and a payment route agreed before the work starts.

This is the longest section in the course because it is the one that decides whether your first client becomes a second client. The payment half is written for your country specifically, including the parts most courses avoid.

How You Get Paid: Local Clients and International Ones

This is the chapter that decides whether the rest of the book turns into money. It is also the chapter most online advice gets wrong, because most online advice assumes you live in a country with a full set of payment rails. If you do, the short version is at the end of this section. If you do not, the rest of this section is for you.

> **THE ONE RULE THAT PREVENTS ALMOST EVERY PROBLEM**
>
> **Agree the payment route with the client before you agree the price.** Not after the work is done, not in the invoice, not when they ask for your bank details. Before.
>
> A client who cannot pay you the way you need is not a client. They are a conversation. Finding that out on delivery day is the most expensive lesson in this book, and it is entirely avoidable with one question asked early.

How money actually crosses a border

When a client in another country pays you, the money does not travel directly. It moves through a chain, and every link in that chain is a place where it can stop. Knowing the chain tells you which question to ask.

1. **The client pays something**
   A card, a PayPal balance, a bank transfer, a mobile wallet, a local payment method. What they can use depends on *their* country, not yours.

2. **A processor authorises it**
   Stripe, PayPal, Adyen, a regional gateway. This is where most cross-border problems originate, because processors operate country by country.

3. **A platform holds it**
   If you sell through a marketplace or course platform, they hold the money and pay you later, on their schedule, at their minimum.

4. **It is paid out to you**
   A bank deposit in your local currency, a PayPal transfer, or a wallet credit. **This is the link that fails most often**, and it is the one nobody checks before they start.

EXPLAIN Buyer-side and seller-side are independent. What your client can use to pay has nothing to do with what you can receive. A platform can be perfectly good for your buyers and completely useless for paying you.

SHOW *Example — fictional.* A writer in Nairobi sells a $25 template pack. Buyers pay by card without difficulty. The platform's payout page then shows one option: PayPal. The writer's PayPal account can send but cannot receive. Fourteen sales, $350, stuck behind a payout route that was never tested.

DO Before you build anything, open the payout settings of every platform you are considering and write down, in one sentence, exactly how money would reach your bank account.

CHECK Can you name the rail, the currency, the minimum payout and the delay? If any of those four is a guess, you have not finished checking.

The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

Do this once per platform. It takes about twenty minutes and it prevents weeks of wasted work.

QUESTION	WHERE TO LOOK	WHAT A USABLE ANSWER LOOKS LIKE
1. Does this platform pay out to my country?	The platform's own payout-settings page or help article — never a blog post, never a YouTube video	Your country named on the platform's own list, with the payout currency
2. Through which rail?	The same page	A named method: local bank deposit, PayPal, Payoneer, wallet. "Contact support" is not an answer
3. What is the minimum and the delay?	The payout help article	A number and a schedule, so you can plan cash flow
4. What does it cost in total?	The pricing page *and* the fees help article — they often disagree	Platform fee plus processing fee, added together, expressed as a percentage of a typical sale

TWO RULES THAT WILL SAVE YOU MONEY

Read the payout page, not the signup page. Almost every platform lets you sign up from almost anywhere. That tells you nothing. The gate is payout.

Check whether two platforms share a rail. If two services both pay through the same underlying processor, they are not backups of each other. When that one rail has a problem, both stop at once. Verify the underlying rail, not just the brand on the front.

Local clients versus international clients

These are two different problems and they need two different answers. Do not let one delay the other.

	LOCAL CLIENTS	INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS
What works	Bank transfer, mobile wallet, cash, a local card gateway. Almost always available to an individual with no registered business.	A licensed remittance corridor, a platform that pays out to your country, or an employer's own payroll route.
Speed	Same day, often same hour	Days to weeks, depending on the platform's payout schedule
What can block it	Nothing much, if you have an account in your own name	Country eligibility, missing documents, a rail that does not reach you
Best first move	Start here. Local clients pay for your proof.	Test the payout route with a small real payment before you promise anything

THE TEST PAYMENT

Before you quote a single international client, run one small real transaction end to end: sell something cheap — a $5 template, a $10 review, a single small job — and take it all the way to money in your account.

This costs you one afternoon and one small fee. It converts every assumption in this chapter into a fact, and it is the single most useful hour in this entire book.

What to say to a client about payment

Clients are not suspicious of payment questions. They are suspicious of vague ones. Say the route plainly, in the first conversation, in writing.

COPY-READY: THE PAYMENT-ROUTING MESSAGE

Before we start, one practical thing so neither of us has a surprise at the end.

I am paid by **[route: bank transfer / a named platform / a licensed transfer service]**. The money arrives in **[currency]**, and I can start work as soon as the first payment shows on my side.

If you would rather use a different method, tell me now and I will check whether it works — I would rather spend five minutes on this today than a week on it later.

For **[amount]** the split is **[50]** % to start and **[50]** % on delivery.

COPY-READY: WHEN A PAYMENT IS LATE

Hello **[name]** — checking in on the **[amount]** for **[work]**, which I sent on **[date]**. It has not shown on my side yet.

Could you confirm the date it was sent and the reference number? If it has not gone out yet, no problem — just let me know when it will, and I will plan around that.

Pricing when the route costs money

Cross-border routes cost the sender or the receiver money. Decide who absorbs it before you quote, and put it in the price rather than discovering it later.

WORKED EXAMPLE — TARGET ARITHMETIC, NOT A FORECAST

```
Your price for the work: $100
Transfer or platform cost, if you absorb it: $5–$15
What actually reaches you: $85–$95
```

Two ways to handle it: quote a price that already includes the cost, or state plainly that transfer fees are the sender's. What you must not do is quote $100 and then argue about $12 after delivery.

NEVER DO THESE THINGS, WHATEVER ANYONE TELLS YOU

— **Never enter a false country, name or address** on a payment platform. It breaches the provider's terms, it usually fails identity verification anyway, and the consequence is a frozen balance and a closed account — with your customers refunded and your earnings gone.

— **Never use a relative's or friend's account abroad** to receive money that is yours. It is the same misrepresentation with extra steps, and it puts their account at risk too.

— **Never use a VPN to open a financial account** in a country you do not live in.

— **Never buy or rent a verified account.** The seller keeps access to it.

— **Never accept payment in a form your country restricts.** Several countries prohibit or restrict virtual-asset transactions; check your own before you accept anything unusual.

The published terms are unambiguous about this. Most platforms require you not to "create an account using a false identity or information, or on behalf of someone other than yourself", and prohibit misrepresenting your "identity, location or credentials". The stated remedy is suspension or termination, and where an underlying processor makes the final call it is often not appealable.

The legitimate routes, in the order worth trying

#	ROUTE	WHO IT SUITS	WHAT TO VERIFY FIRST
1	A platform that publishes your country on its own payout list, paying into a local bank account in local currency	Anyone selling digital products or courses	That the payout page offers *bank deposit*, not "PayPal only", for your country
2	A licensed money-transfer service (Western Union, MoneyGram, Remitly, WorldRemit and similar) for a one-off client payment	Freelancers and service sellers with a single client	That the receiving country and currency appear on the provider's own corridor list
3	An employer's own payroll or contractor route	Remote employees and long-term contractors	That the employer has paid a contractor in your country before — ask them directly
4	Registering as an exporter of services and receiving into a foreign-currency account	Anyone earning regularly from abroad	Your own country's rules. In several countries this unlocks full retention of foreign-currency earnings and an international card — ask a local accountant, do not guess
5	Trading through a properly registered company in the country where the payout account sits	Established sellers doing meaningful volume	Real incorporation, a real bank account there, real accounting, and any home-country approval required. Legitimate, but slow and expensive — not a shortcut

IF YOU ALREADY HAVE FULL PAYMENT RAILS

Then most of this chapter is not your constraint, and your fastest route is whatever your clients already use: Stripe, PayPal, a card gateway. Skim the four verification questions above anyway — the platform fee difference between two similar services is often several percentage points, and on a hundred sales a year that is real money.

Tax and registration, stated honestly

THIS IS NOT TAX ADVICE, AND THE RULES ARE LOCAL

Almost every country requires you to declare income you earn, and most require some form of tax registration once you are trading. What that means in practice — a tax number, a business registration, a turnover-tax threshold, a VAT threshold — differs enormously from country to country, and the thresholds change.

What to do: find your national tax authority's own website, look for the page on registering as a sole trader or self-employed person, and read the current threshold. If your earnings are small, you may be below every threshold. If they are not, register. A local accountant charges very little for one hour of advice, and that hour is worth more than any general guidance in a book written for the whole world.

Keep a simple record from your first sale: date, client, amount, currency, what it was for, and the fee deducted. That one sheet makes tax time trivial and makes you look professional if anyone ever asks.

IF YOU SELL THROUGH A MARKETPLACE, READ THIS

Large platforms are often the *merchant of record*, meaning they handle sales tax and VAT for the buyer and remit it themselves. That does not remove your obligation to declare the income you receive. It changes what you have to collect, not whether you have to report.

Some platforms also require a tax form before they will pay you at all — a W-9 if you are in the United States, a W-8 series form if you are not, or a local equivalent. If a form is required and not submitted, payouts are usually paused. Complete it early rather than after your first sale.

09

SECTION NINE

Turning One Client Into Many

How to collect testimonials honestly, write a case study from a small job, ask for referrals without embarrassment, raise your price without losing the client, convert a one-off job into a monthly retainer, and stop one client from consuming your whole week.

01 Testimonials: ask, never write, never invent

02 The case-study format

03 The referral request script

04 The price-increase message

05 Converting a one-off job into a monthly retainer

06 Protecting your time from your best client

Getting the first client is the hardest part of this business. Getting the second one from the same place is the cheapest.

This section is short because the work is small: four messages and one habit. Done consistently, it is what turns a first project into a monthly figure instead of a story you tell once.

09. Testimonials: Ask, Never Write, Never Invent

A testimonial in the client's own words is proof. A testimonial you drafted and they nodded at is a liability. A testimonial you invented is fraud, and in a market this small it will be found out.

1. **Ask at the right moment**
   Ask in the same message where you deliver the file and they are happiest — or the day after they say thank you. Not three weeks later, when the job is a memory.

2. **Ask two specific questions**
   "What was the problem before we started?" and "What changed after?" Specific questions produce specific answers, and specific answers are what persuade the next client.

3. **Never write it for them**
   Do not send a paragraph and ask them to approve it. If they cannot write it, ask them to send a voice note on Telegram and quote it accurately, with their permission.

4. **Ask permission to publish, with their name or without**
   Some clients are happy to be named; some are not. Both are fine. Get the answer in writing.

COPY-READY: TESTIMONIAL REQUEST

Selam `[name]`, I am glad the `[deliverable]` is working for you.

Two short questions, and your answers help me more than anything else:

1. What was the problem before we started?
2. What changed after?

Just two or three lines is plenty. May I show your answer to other businesses, with your business name, or would you prefer I leave the name out? Either is completely fine.

Thank you,
`[your name]`

The Case-Study Format

One page. Four headings. This is what turns five small jobs into a portfolio that looks like a practice.

HEADING	WHAT YOU WRITE	KEEP IT TO
The situation	Who the client is and what was wrong, factually	2 sentences
What I did	The exact work, in the order you did it	3 bullets

HEADING	WHAT YOU WRITE	KEEP IT TO
The result	What changed — measured where possible, described where not	2 sentences

HEADING	WHAT YOU WRITE	KEEP IT TO
In their words	The client's own two lines, with permission	1 quote

Add one image — a before and after, side by side. Keep the file under 2 MB. Publish it in your portfolio and send it to the next prospect in the same industry.

> **NEVER CLAIM A RESULT YOU CANNOT POINT TO**
>
> If the client's sales rose after your work but they also changed their prices, do not write "my design increased sales by 30%". Write "the shop reported more walk-in customers asking for the items now shown with prices". Honest specificity persuades; inflated numbers eventually get questioned, and the questioning is what costs you the next client.

The Referral Request

Referrals are the cheapest clients you will ever get, and almost nobody asks for them because it feels like begging. It is not begging. It is a normal business question, and most satisfied clients are glad to answer it.

COPY-READY: REFERRAL REQUEST

Selam [name], thank you again for the [project] — it was a pleasure to work on.

I am taking on [two] more clients this month, and I would rather work with people you know than with strangers.

Is there one person in your network who has the same problem you had — [describe the problem briefly]? If you introduce us, I will take [10%] off their first project, and I will do the first job for you at a reduced rate next time as a thank you.

No pressure at all if nobody comes to mind.

Thank you,
[your name]

Ask **once per client per job**. Asking twice in a month turns a warm client into an uncomfortable one.

The Price-Increase Message

Your first prices are beginner prices. As you collect proof, they should rise, and the way to raise them is in advance, in writing, with the reason attached.

COPY-READY: PRICE INCREASE

Selam [name], thank you for the work this year — you have been one of my first clients and I have learned a lot from it.

From [date], my price for [deliverable] changes from [old amount] to [new amount] USD. The reason is that the work now includes [what you have added — faster turnaround, extra formats, priority scheduling].

Anything you book before [date] stays at the current price, and if you want to book [three] projects now at the old rate, I am happy to hold that.

Thank you for understanding,
[your name]

HOW MUCH, AND HOW OFTEN

Raise prices for existing clients by a modest step — around 15% to 25% — and give at least two weeks' notice. Raise prices for new clients straight away; they have no old price to compare with.

If a client leaves after a price rise, the arithmetic usually still works: two clients at the higher price can equal three at the old one, and they take less of your week. Losing a client over a fair price increase is not a failure.

Converting to a Monthly Retainer

A one-off job pays once. A retainer pays every month for work you have already learned how to do. This is the single biggest upgrade available to a beginner, and it usually starts with one sentence after a successful project.

COPY-READY: RETAINER PROPOSAL

Selam [name], I am glad the [project] worked well.

Most of my clients end up needing the same things every month — [e.g. twelve posts, a price update, two edited clips]. Instead of quoting each one separately, I can do it as a monthly arrangement:

[amount] **USD per month**, which includes [item 1], [item 2] and [item 3], delivered by [the 25th] each month. Payment on the [1st].

That works out cheaper than booking each item separately, and it means you never have to remember to ask.

Would you like to start with one month and see how it goes?

Start retainers with a one-month trial rather than a twelve-month contract. A client who is happy in month one will continue; a client locked into a year of work they did not want becomes a problem for both of you.

Protecting Your Time From Your Best Client

The client who pays most is also the client most likely to consume everything. Four rules keep that from happening.

01 One client, maximum half your week

If a single client takes more than about half of your working time, you have a job with extra steps and no security. Keep at least two active clients, always.

02 Define office hours and hold them

Tell clients when you answer messages: for example 8:00 to 12:00 and 15:00 to 18:00. Answering at 23:40 teaches the client that 23:40 is acceptable. It is not sustainable, and it is not what they are paying for.

03 Never let a retainer become unlimited

Write in the retainer what is included: a number of posts, a number of revisions, a number of calls. "Unlimited small changes" is the sentence that ends a retainer badly.

04 Keep sending outreach even when you are busy

One message a day, minimum, forever. The month you stop prospecting is the month your only client decides to pause. Every freelancer learns this the same way: the hard way.

Section 09 checklist

- [ ] I have asked my most recent client for a two-line testimonial in their own words.
- [ ] I have turned one finished job into a one-page case study with a before-and-after image.
- [ ] I have asked one satisfied client for one referral.
- [ ] I have written my price-increase message and saved it for the right moment.
- [ ] I have offered one client a one-month retainer.
- [ ] I have written down my office hours and I am holding them this week.
- [ ] I have sent one real message to one real business.

10

SECTION TEN

The 14-Day Launch Plan

Fourteen days, one ninety-minute block a day, each day with an objective, a task, a worked example, an output and a check. Then the 30-day outreach cadence that turns the launch into a habit, with the tracking sheet that keeps all thirty proposals visible.

01 How the fourteen days work

02 Days 1 to 4: decide, write, build

03 Days 5 to 9: finish the proof, build the list, price it

04 Days 10 to 14: send, test, review

05 The 30-day outreach cadence

06 The proposal tracking sheet

Ninety minutes a day for fourteen days. That is the whole commitment, and every day has one output you can see at the end of it.

If you miss a day, do not restart. Move to the next day's task and catch up on the weekend. The plan exists to make starting possible, not to make stopping feel like failure.

10. How the Fourteen Days Work

Each day has five parts. The **output** is what must exist when you close your phone. The **check** is how you know it is done properly rather than approximately.

> **BEFORE DAY 1**
>
> Decide the time of day you will work and put it in your phone as a repeating alarm. Ninety minutes in one block beats three half-hours scattered across the day, and a fixed hour beats good intentions.

DAY 01 Choose one service

OBJECTIVE	Turn a general skill into one sellable service.
TASK	Complete the skills inventory and score three ideas with the eight-factor method from section 02. Pick the highest scorer and write your positioning sentence.
EXAMPLE	Example scenario — fictional: "I help cafes and restaurants in a regional city get a clean, priced menu in four days."
OUTPUT	One written sentence, saved in your notes app, plus the three scored ideas.
CHECK	☐ I can say my service out loud without hesitating. ☐ I can name twenty buyers for it.

DAY 02 Write your profile

OBJECTIVE	Sound like an offer, not a CV.
TASK	Write all five bios from section 03. Create the professional email address. Paste the signature. Take a daylight photo against a plain wall.
EXAMPLE	Headline: "Menu and price-list design for cafes — printable and priced in four days."
OUTPUT	Five saved bios, a working email address, a signature, one square photo.
CHECK	☐ A friend can repeat back what I sell after reading it once. ☐ The signature shows my phone number and city.

DAY 03 Build sample project A

OBJECTIVE Have one piece of proof that a stranger can look at.

TASK Use the section 04 workflow. Pick a real local business with a visible problem. Make one page or one deliverable — not the whole job. Label it as a sample.

EXAMPLE Example scenario — fictional: a rebuilt menu page for the commercial district Beans Cafe, with prices and a vegetarian marker.

OUTPUT One PDF under 2 MB, named `Sample-Menu-YourName.pdf`, and one square image of it.

CHECK

- [ ] The sample label is visible on the work itself.
- [ ] The file opens on my own phone without wi-fi.

DAY 04 Build sample project B

OBJECTIVE Show a second, different type of work.

TASK Build the twelve-post content calendar, the rewritten listing, or the bookkeeping sheet — whichever is closest to the service you chose on day 1.

EXAMPLE Example scenario — fictional: a 12-post plan for Lakeview Style House, in a four-column table.

OUTPUT A second labelled PDF and its square preview image.

CHECK

- [ ] It looks like a finished deliverable, not notes.
- [ ] Every entry is something the client could act on tomorrow.

DAY 05 Build sample project C

OBJECTIVE Complete the set of three.

TASK Build the third sample in a third format — if the first two were documents, make this one a spreadsheet or an image set.

EXAMPLE Example scenario — fictional: a rewritten day-by-day tour listing for Highland Tour Link.

OUTPUT Three labelled samples in total, all saved in one folder.

CHECK

- [ ] All three carry the sample label.
- [ ] All three relate to the one service I chose.

DAY 06 Build the one-page portfolio

OBJECTIVE One link you can send to anyone in five seconds.

TASK Assemble the page in Google Docs using the section 04 layout. Export as PDF. Upload to Drive with view-only sharing. Test the link in a private window.

EXAMPLE Top: name, headline, phone. Middle: three images with two-line captions. Bottom: deliverable bullets, price range, sample label.

OUTPUT `YourName-Service-Portfolio.pdf` under 3 MB, plus a working share link.

CHECK

- [ ] The link opens for someone who is not signed into my account.
- [ ] The whole page fits on one screen on a phone.

DAY 07 Build the prospect list

OBJECTIVE Twenty named businesses with contact routes.

TASK Create the ten-column Google Sheet from section 05. Research twenty businesses on Google Maps and the directories. Write one specific observation for each.

EXAMPLE "Menu photos from 2023, no prices, last post 4 months ago."

OUTPUT Twenty rows, each with a contact route and a real observation.

CHECK

- [ ] No row says "needs better marketing".
- [ ] Every row has a way to reach a human being.

DAY 08 Set your prices

OBJECTIVE Three tiers, three numbers, no ranges.

TASK Write your good/better/complete packages from section 07. Decide your deposit rule per client type. Save the deposit sentence and the scope document.

EXAMPLE Good $11 · Better $3,200 · Complete $35. Example prices only.

OUTPUT A written price list with three scopes and one number each.

CHECK

- [ ] I can say each price out loud without adding "but we can discuss".
- [ ] Every tier is work I would be content to deliver.

DAY 09 Prepare every script

OBJECTIVE Never write a message from scratch under pressure.

TASK Save all ten scripts from section 06 and all eight objection answers from section 07 into your notes app, grouped and labelled.

EXAMPLE Folders: Outreach · Follow-ups · Price · Objections · Delivery.

OUTPUT Everything two taps away on your phone.

CHECK

- [ ] I found script 1 in under ten seconds on my phone.
- [ ] Each script still has its [placeholders] intact.

DAY 10 Send the first five messages

OBJECTIVE Become someone who sends, not someone who plans to send.

TASK Send script 1, personalised, to the top five prospects in your sheet. Log the date and set the follow-up date. Do not send ten. Five is the target, and five done properly beats ten copied.

EXAMPLE Send the message with the sample attached as a single square image first, then the PDF.

OUTPUT Five messages sent, five rows updated in the sheet.

CHECK

- [ ] Each message names something I actually saw.
- [ ] Each ends with one question.

DAY 11 Join the communities

OBJECTIVE Be visible where your buyers already talk.

TASK Join ten Telegram or Facebook groups. Read the pinned rules in each. Answer three questions properly, with no pitch attached. Update your profile bio with your headline formula.

EXAMPLE Answer a Sheets formula question in a small-business group with the exact formula and one line of explanation.

OUTPUT Three public answers written, ten groups joined, bio updated.

CHECK

- [ ] None of my three answers contained an offer.
- [ ] I know which day each group allows promotion.

DAY 12 Check the platform question, honestly

OBJECTIVE Decide whether to use an international platform, and know why.

TASK Pick one platform. Read its official help pages for both registration eligibility and payout methods available where you live. Write down the date you checked and what it said. Also complete your LinkedIn profile and send ten connection requests with short notes.

EXAMPLE Write: "Checked 15 Sept 2026. Payout page lists these methods for your country: [list]. Registration: [allowed / not allowed / unclear]."

OUTPUT One written eligibility note with a date, plus ten LinkedIn requests sent.

CHECK

- [ ] I did not guess, and I did not use a VPN to look at anything.
- [ ] My note says where I read it.

DAY 13 Test your payment route

OBJECTIVE Know exactly how money reaches you before a client asks.

TASK Ask a friend or family member to send you a small amount to your wallet and to your bank account. Note every step, the time it took, and any verification prompt. Then write your payment paragraph for local clients and your payment message for foreign clients.

EXAMPLE Note: "a mobile wallet to a mobile wallet, $1.25 arrived in under a minute. Above $120 there is an extra confirmation step."

OUTPUT A written payment paragraph, and a tested receiving route.

CHECK

- [ ] I have seen money arrive in my own account.
- [ ] I can explain the route to a client in two sentences.

DAY 14 Send, follow up, review

OBJECTIVE Close the loop and set the cadence you will keep.

TASK Send five more first messages. Send follow-up 1 to everyone from day 10 who has not replied. Review your sheet: how many contacted, how many replied, what wording got the reply. Change one thing in your message based on what you learned.

EXAMPLE Example scenario — fictional: 10 contacted, 1 reply, 0 sales. The reply came from the message that mentioned a specific missing price. So every future message mentions a specific missing detail.

OUTPUT Fifteen total messages sent, follow-ups logged, one change made and written down.

CHECK

- [ ] Fifteen messages have actually left my phone.
- [ ] My sheet has a next action date for every row.

The 30-Day Outreach Cadence

The fourteen days build the machine. The next thirty days run it. The target is **thirty high-quality proposals** — not thirty messages copied and pasted, and not thirty in one afternoon.

WEEK	FIRST MESSAGES	FOLLOW-UPS	PORTFOLIO WORK
Week 1	8	3	Add one case study or testimonial

WEEK	FIRST MESSAGES	FOLLOW-UPS	PORTFOLIO WORK
Week 2	8	6	Add a fourth sample in your niche

WEEK	FIRST MESSAGES	FOLLOW-UPS	PORTFOLIO WORK
Week 3	7	8	Rewrite your first message based on replies

WEEK	FIRST MESSAGES	FOLLOW-UPS	PORTFOLIO WORK
Week 4	7	8	Build one case study from any paid work won
Total	**30**	**25**	Four improvements

This is a target cadence, not a forecast of results. Sending thirty proposals does not guarantee a client — see the final challenge at the back of this course.

TARGET EXAMPLE — NOT A PREDICTION

```
30 proposals + 25 follow-ups = 55 touches
55 touches / 30 days = under 2 per day
```

Arithmetic, not a forecast. The volume is deliberately small because each touch is researched. Volume without research produces nothing.

The Proposal Tracking Sheet

Same sheet as your prospect list, or a second tab in the same file. Nine columns, and the discipline is that nothing is ever left without a next action date.

COLUMN	WHAT GOES IN IT
Date sent	The day the message left your phone
Prospect	Business or person name
Channel	Instagram · Telegram · Email · LinkedIn · Platform · In person
Which script	1 to 10, so you learn which ones work
Personalisation used	The specific observation in the message
Reply?	Yes · No · Not yet
Outcome	Quoted · Won · Lost · Dormant · No reply
Next action date	Never blank. Every row has one.
What I learned	One line, written the day the reply comes or does not

After thirty rows, read the "What I learned" column from top to bottom. That column, not this course, is what tells you which message and which niche to double down on.

THE ONLY METRIC THAT MATTERS IN THE FIRST MONTH

Messages sent per day. Not replies, not sales, not followers. Replies are an outcome you do not control. Messages are the input you do control completely, and after thirty of them you will know more about your market than any course can tell you.

CLOSING

Common Mistakes and Their Fixes

Fourteen mistakes that slow beginners down. Each one has a fix you can apply this week.

THE MISTAKE	WHY IT COSTS YOU	THE FIX
Offering five services at once	Buyers cannot tell what you do, so they buy nothing	One service, one buyer type, ninety days
Competing on price	Caps your income and attracts the hardest clients	Sell specificity and speed instead; never quote a range
Waiting for a perfect portfolio	Weeks pass with no messages sent	One labelled sample is enough to start; build the rest while you prospect
Copying a script without personalising it	The buyer can tell, and it reads as spam	One specific factual observation in every first message
Sending one message and stopping	Most replies come from the second or third touch	Three follow-ups, then dormant, with dates in your sheet
Quoting a price range	The buyer hears the lower number as your real price	One number per scope; offer a smaller scope with its own number
Discounting the moment they hesitate	Teaches them your first price was not real	Reduce scope, not price
No scope document	Revisions expand until the job is unprofitable	Six-line scope document before every job
Unlimited revisions	Turns a paid job into unpaid work	Two rounds, one consolidated list, new direction quoted separately
Starting work before the deposit	You lose your ability to be paid at all	Deposit rule by client type, stated in the scope
Agreeing the payment route after delivery	The argument starts when you are least able to walk away	Agree the route in writing before work begins
Uploading large files at 19:00	Reported worst-case speeds fall as low as 98 Kb/s in that window	Compress, send text first, upload early morning or late night
Faking a country, renting an account or taking crypto	Account closure, lost balance, and in the case of crypto, activity prohibited where you live	Use the licensed routes in section 08, or wait until you can register properly
Stopping outreach once one client arrives	The month that client pauses, your income goes to zero	One message a day, forever, even when busy

CLOSING

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need a business licence to freelance?

Not to start. A local client can pay you as an individual through a mobile wallet or a bank transfer, with no licence. You need a registered business — trade licence, TIN and Memorandum of Association — when you want a merchant gateway, a service-exporter account or an international card. Section 08 covers the sequence.

Can I get paid from abroad without PayPal?

Yes, through your regulator-licensed remittance corridor. Your client sends via operators such as Western Union, MoneyGram, Remitly, WorldRemit, Ria, Taptap Send, TalkRemit, Xpress Money, Transfast, Thunes or Alansari, or a wallet corridor such as a wallet remittance corridor or a mobile-money wallet, and you receive dollars as cash, bank deposit or wallet credit. The sender pays the transfer fee and the FX spread, so agree that in writing first. Direct PayPal, Payoneer, Wise or Stripe receiving is not verified for a resident of a country with limited payment access, and this course will not pretend otherwise.

Will clients trust someone from a country with limited payment access?

Some will not, and you will never know why they did not reply. Most will, if you remove the risks they can see: written scope, regular updates, compressed files with backup links, staged delivery, and honest answers about what you have and have not done before. Trust is built by predictability, not by reassurance.

What if my internet fails during a call?

Send a written summary of everything covered within the hour, and say in advance that you will. Put it in your "how I work" note. A dropped call costs you nothing if the client already knows what happens next; it costs you the job if they are left wondering.

How much should I charge as a beginner?

Enough to make the work worth doing, low enough that a cautious buyer will take a first chance on you. Use the example ranges in section 02 as a starting point, adjust for your city and your proof, and raise your prices after every two or three completed jobs. Never quote a range, and never discount — reduce scope instead.

Should I work for free?

One small labelled sample, made proactively for a business you chose, is a good investment. Unlimited free work on request is not. The difference is who chose the scope: you or them. If a client asks for a large free test before the first paid job, offer a small paid first stage instead — and if they refuse, that is your answer.

What if a client refuses to pay?

This is why the deposit exists. If it happens anyway: stop work immediately, send one calm written message stating what was delivered, what was agreed and what is outstanding, and keep every message and file as evidence. For small amounts, the practical cost of chasing often exceeds the amount. The lesson is the deposit rule, applied earlier next time.

Is freelancing legal where you live?

Earning money for services you provide is legal, and registering for a TIN is mandatory under your income-tax law. What is not legal is unlicensed money remittance, and virtual-asset activity is prohibited unless expressly authorised.

Receiving payment through a licensed wallet, a bank transfer or a licensed remittance corridor is the ordinary, legal route.

Will this work if I only have a phone?

Yes for almost everything: research, messages, samples, price lists, invoices and delivery. The two tasks that are genuinely awkward are multi-page PDF layout and long video edits; section 04 and the sample workflows give phone alternatives for both, and one borrowed laptop session speeds things up if you can get one. Do not delay your first message waiting for a laptop.

What if nobody replies to my first twenty messages?

That is common, and it is not a verdict. Check three things in order: did each message contain a specific factual observation, did it end with one question, and was it under 120 words. Then send twenty more with those three things fixed. If replies still do not come after forty messages, the problem is usually the buyer type rather than the message — change niche, not effort.

How long until I get my first client?

Nobody can tell you, and anyone who gives you a number is guessing. What you control is the volume and quality of your outreach. Some people get a reply in the first week; some send fifty messages before the first yes. Plan for the second case, and be pleasantly surprised by the first.

Do I need to show my face?

You need a photo, and it needs to be a real photo of you. Buyers are deciding whether to trust a stranger with money, and a clear daylight headshot against a plain wall does that job better than anything else you can do in ten minutes. You do not need video calls to start.

Can I do this alongside a job or university?

Yes, and most readers will. Ninety minutes a day for fourteen days is the build phase; after that, one hour of outreach a day is enough to keep the pipeline alive. The plan is designed around a single fixed block per day, because scattered minutes produce scattered work.

Do I have to register on a freelancing platform?

No. Direct outreach, Telegram and LinkedIn reach buyers without any platform. If you do use a platform, verify its current registration eligibility and its payout availability for your country on the platform's own official pages first, and never misrepresent your country to get in.

CLOSING

How to Spot a Fake Opportunity

Freelancers who are looking for their first client are the exact audience that fraud is built for. These are the patterns reported where you live, and they repeat.

> **THE YOUR CENTRAL BANK OR FINANCIAL REGULATOR WARNING**

The your regulator has issued a public warning that fraudsters impersonate people and institutions on WhatsApp, Telegram, Facebook, email, SMS and through fake phone calls in order to request urgent transfers. The legal basis cited includes your regulator Proclamation 1359/2025 Article 6(28) and the your financial-consumer-protection rules.

Report suspected fraud to **your regulator's complaint address** or to the short code **6230**.

THE DOCUMENTED TELEGRAM ACCOUNT-TAKEOVER SCAM

local press documented a scam in which fraudsters pose as Telegram security staff, persuade the victim to hand over their password and a one-time code, seize the account, and then message the victim's contacts asking for money.

No legitimate platform, bank or wallet will ever ask you for a one-time code. Not Telegram, not a mobile wallet, not your bank, not a client. If someone asks, the conversation is over.

The seven patterns to recognise

PATTERN	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT TO DO
Registration fee	"Pay $2 to activate your worker account."	Stop. Real work never charges you to be hired.
Pay to release your payment	"Your payment is held — pay the release fee to withdraw it."	Stop. This is the advance-fee pattern. There is no held payment.
Account rental	"Use your name and ID to open an account; we will pay you monthly."	Refuse. You carry the legal liability and lose control of the money.
Fake recruiter on Telegram	A "hiring manager" with a company logo, no verifiable company, pushing you to a private chat fast	Verify the company independently, on its own website, with a phone number you found yourself.
OTP or bank details request	"Send the code you have received so we can verify you."	Refuse and block. This is the account-takeover scam.
Commission-only "agent" wanting your ID	"We will find you clients; send your ID and a signed blank form."	Refuse. Your ID plus a blank form is a document problem you cannot undo.
Pay-before-work platforms	Any "freelance platform" that asks for money before you have ever been paid	Leave. Also check whether the platform is even available to people in countries with limited payment access before investing time.

The eight-point legitimacy checklist

Before you send documents, pay anything, or start work for a new contact, run this list. If you cannot answer three or more points, slow down.

- [ ] I found this opportunity myself, rather than being pushed into it by someone who contacted me first.
- [ ] I can find the company's own website or a listing that I verified independently, not a link they sent me.
- [ ] I have a phone number or address that I found myself, not the one in their message.
- [ ] They have not asked me for money, in any form, at any stage.

- [ ] They have not asked for a one-time code, a password, or my bank or wallet details.
- [ ] They have not asked for my ID documents, or for a blank or partly blank form.
- [ ] They have told me, in writing, what the work is, what it pays, and when it is paid.
- [ ] The payment route is one of the normal routes — wallet, bank transfer, or a licensed remittance corridor.

> **THE ONE RULE THAT COVERS ALMOST EVERYTHING**
>
> **Money flows towards you, never away from you.** A real client pays you for work. Any arrangement where you send money, buy a "starter package", pay a release fee, or hand over account access in order to receive work is not a job. It is the scam, wearing a job's clothes.

Sources & Further Reading

Every platform figure in this book traces to one of the sources below, all checked in September 2026. Platform country lists, payout methods and fees change often — confirm anything you intend to rely on at the source itself.

1. Gumroad — pricing and fee structure — https://gumroad.com/pricing
2. Gumroad — getting paid, bank-payout country list and payout schedule — https://gumroad.com/help/article/13-getting-paid
3. Gumroad — fees in detail — https://gumroad.com/help/article/66-gumroads-fees
4. Gumroad — payout settings, identity documents and tax IDs — https://gumroad.com/help/article/260-your-payout-settings-page
5. Gumroad — account suspension and what causes it — https://gumroad.com/help/article/160-suspension
6. Gumroad — terms of service (identity, location and account rules) — https://gumroad.com/terms
7. Lemon Squeezy — supported countries for sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/getting-started/supported-countries
8. Lemon Squeezy — W-8 and W-9 tax forms for non-US sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/tax-forms/w8-w9-forms
9. Lemon Squeezy — pricing — https://www.lemonsqueezy.com/pricing
10. Stripe — cross-border payouts and supported regions — https://docs.stripe.com/connect/cross-border-payouts
11. IRS — About Form W-8BEN — https://www.irs.gov/forms-pubs/about-form-w-8-ben
12. IRS — United States income tax treaties A to Z — https://www.irs.gov/businesses/international-businesses/united-states-income-tax-treaties-a-to-z
13. Whop — payout methods and countries — https://docs.whop.com/manage-your-business/manage-payouts/payout-methods
14. Payhip — how sellers get paid — https://help.payhip.com/article/173-how-do-i-get-paid
15. Ko-fi — how creators get paid — https://help.ko-fi.com/hc/en-us/articles/115003980093-How-do-I-get-paid
16. Fungies — countries you can sell from — https://fungies.io/global-availability/
17. Telegram — Telegram Stars for digital goods — https://telegram.org/blog/telegram-stars
18. Google — Business Profile supported countries — https://support.google.com/business/answer/6270107
19. YouTube — Partner Program availability by country — https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/7101720
20. DataReportal — global digital statistics — https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-global-overview-report
21. World Bank — World Development Indicators — https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators
22. International Labour Organization — ILOSTAT employment data — https://ilostat.ilo.org/
23. Internet Society — Internet shutdown and disruption reporting — https://www.internetsociety.org/
24. FATF — virtual asset and payment-service guidance by jurisdiction — https://www.fatf-gafi.org/

Where research could not verify a fact, this book says so in the text and tells you to check it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps deliberately.

CLOSING

Final Checklist

Everything this course asks you to produce, in one list. Tick nothing you have not actually done.

Positioning and profile

- [ ] I have chosen one service, one buyer type and one problem.
- [ ] I have scored my options with the eight-factor method.
- [ ] I have written my positioning sentence and saved it.
- [ ] My headline follows the formula and is under 90 characters.
- [ ] I have written all five bios.
- [ ] My photo is a clear, square, daylight headshot.
- [ ] My professional email address exists and my signature is set.
- [ ] My Telegram, LinkedIn and any platform profile all carry the same headline and photo.

Proof

- [ ] I have built three sample projects, each in a different format.
- [ ] Every sample is labelled as a sample, not client work.
- [ ] My one-page PDF portfolio exists and is under 3 MB.
- [ ] My share link works for someone who is not signed into my account.
- [ ] I can present my portfolio from my phone without using anyone's wi-fi.

Finding buyers

- [ ] My prospect sheet has the ten columns and at least 20 filled rows.
- [ ] Every row has a contact route and a specific factual observation.
- [ ] I have joined ten relevant Telegram or Facebook groups and read the rules.
- [ ] I have contributed at least three answers with no pitch attached.
- [ ] I have checked one platform's registration and payout eligibility for your country, with the date noted.

Selling

- [ ] All ten outreach scripts and eight objection answers are saved on my phone.
- [ ] I have sent at least 10 personalised first messages and logged them.
- [ ] Every message names something I actually observed.
- [ ] My price list has three tiers with one number each and no ranges.
- [ ] I have written down what makes me walk away.

Delivering and getting paid

- [ ] My scope document, onboarding, progress, delivery and invoice templates are saved.
- [ ] I have tested receiving money into my own wallet and bank account.
- [ ] I know my wallet's current limits from the provider's own app.
- [ ] I have a written payment paragraph for local clients and a payment message for foreign clients.
- [ ] I know the sequence for later: TIN, then business licence, then service-exporter registration.

After the first client

- [ ] I have asked for a two-line testimonial in the client's own words.
- [ ] I have built one case study from real work.
- [ ] I have asked for one referral.
- [ ] I have offered one client a one-month retainer.
- [ ] I am still sending one message a day, even when busy.

CLOSING

Final Challenge: Send 30 High-Quality Proposals

This is the challenge the whole course builds towards. Thirty proposals, tracked in one sheet, over thirty days.

Read the definition carefully, because most people who think they completed this challenge did not. A proposal only counts if all six conditions below are true.

A proposal counts only if

01 It names a real business or a real job post

Not "a cafe in Addis". An actual name you found, with the area and the contact route written in your sheet.

02 It contains one specific factual observation

Something you saw with your own eyes: a missing price, a wrong phone number, a menu photo from 2023, a posting gap of four months.

03 It names the exact deliverable and the timeframe

"One redesigned menu page, print-ready PDF, four days." Not "help with your marketing".

04 It carries proof

A labelled sample or portfolio link. Attached as an image first, then the file, then the link.

05 It ends with one question answerable in a word

"Shall I send the full version?" Not "let me know what you think."

06 It is logged with a follow-up date

Row in the sheet, date sent, follow-up due, status. An untracked message is a message you will forget.

The tracking sheet for the challenge

DAY	PROPOSAL NUMBER	PROSPECT	CHANNEL	SCRIPT USED	OBSERVATION	FOLLOW-UP DUE	OUTCOME
1	01	Example scenario — fictional: the commercial district Beans Cafe	Instagram	1	Menu photo from 2023, no prices	Day 5	No reply yet
1	02	Example scenario — fictional: Lakeview Style House	Telegram	1	Three posts in four months	Day 5	No reply yet

DAY	PROPOSAL NUMBER	PROSPECT	CHANNEL	SCRIPT USED	OBSERVATION	FOLLOW-UP DUE	OUTCOME
2	03	Example scenario — fictional: City Fitness Center	Email	2	No prices on the class schedule	Day 6	Replied, asked price
2	04	Example scenario — fictional: Highland Tour Link	LinkedIn	2	Itinerary in one dense paragraph	Day 6	No reply yet

All names in this table are fictional examples. Build your own rows with real prospects.

THE HONEST PART

Sending thirty proposals does not guarantee a client. It is not a formula with a guaranteed output, and this course will not pretend otherwise. Thirty well-researched proposals puts you in a position where a yes is possible; it does not oblige anyone to say yes.

What thirty proposals does guarantee is information. After thirty, you will know which niche replies, which message wording gets read, which channel is worth your time, and whether your price is realistic. That information is worth more than the course you are reading, because it is about your market and not about the market in general.

THE CHALLENGE, IN NUMBERS

```
30 proposals + 25 follow-ups in 30 days
= about 2 touches per day
```

Two researched touches a day is a habit, not a campaign. That is the entire challenge.

CLOSING

Next Steps

This course got you to a first client. The next course depends on what you want that client to become.

If you would rather have a job than gigs

Course 07 — The Remote Work Starter System. Same profile and portfolio work, aimed at employers who hire remote staff rather than buyers who purchase projects. If you want a monthly salary, a contract and a team, read that one next. Nothing you built here is wasted — the profile, the samples and the outreach skills all transfer directly.

If your clients are local and you want recurring income

Course 09 — The local Online Service Business. How to turn one-off local projects into monthly arrangements, how to register properly when the time comes, and how to build a small service business that does not depend on you being awake at midnight.

If you want to stop selling hours

Course 06 — Sell Digital Products From your country. Package what you already know into a file people pay for: a guide, a template pack, a study pack. The demand-validation method in that course is the same skill you learned here, pointed at a product instead of a client.

If you want the full thirty-day build

Course 10 — the complete 30-day build. A day-by-day programme that combines positioning, portfolio, outreach, delivery and payment into one calendar, for readers who want the whole sequence laid out rather than assembled from separate courses.

ONE LAST THING

You now have the scripts, the structure and the payment routes. What you do not yet have is a message sent today.

Open your prospect sheet. Pick one business. Write one specific observation about it. Send one message before you close this document.

Everything in this course is worth nothing until that message leaves your phone.

NexKit your country — practical digital skills and income systems built for your country. This course is educational material. It is not financial, legal or investment advice, and it does not guarantee income, clients or results of any kind.

FINAL CHALLENGE

Final Challenge: Send 30 High-Quality Proposals

Thirty proposals, each one tailored. Not thirty copy-paste messages — thirty pieces of work that show you read the brief.

01 Use the prospect sheet structure. Ten prospects a day for three days, each with a named decision-maker and a written note about their business.

02 Send proposals 11 to 20. Every proposal must contain the five-part structure from section 06 and one piece of proof relevant to that specific buyer.

03 Send proposals 21 to 25 on a platform if you have verified that people in countries with limited payment access can register and be paid there. If you cannot verify it, send them by direct outreach instead.

04 Send the last five, then work the follow-up ladder on all thirty: follow-up 1 after three days, follow-up 2 after seven, final message after ten.

05 Log every send, every reply, every refusal in the client's own words, and every proposal that turned into a conversation about price.

06 At the end, calculate your reply rate and your proposal-to-conversation rate. Those two numbers, not the outcome, are what month two is built on.

Sending thirty high-quality proposals does not guarantee a client. It does guarantee that you will know your own reply rate — which is the number that turns freelancing from a lottery into a process.

It is a structured exercise, not a promise. What it produces is a working asset you can run again at higher volume.

GLOBAL EDITION · FIRST EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

The Freelancer Starter System

How to Get Your First Paying Client Online

LEGAL, DISCLAIMER AND HOW TO READ THIS

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The local Freelancer Starter System — First Edition · September 2026

Publisher: NexKit your country Editorial Team. This course was written, edited and fact-checked by the NexKit your country Editorial Team. It is not attributed to any individual author, and no personal credentials, photographs or biographies are presented.

What this course is

A practical, your country-specific operating manual for getting a first paying client as a freelancer. It covers how the freelance market actually behaves, how to pick one skill and one buyer, how to build a profile that reads like an offer rather than a CV, how to build three labelled sample projects when you have no clients, four channels for finding work, ten copy-ready scripts, how to answer objections without dropping your price, how to deliver the work, and exactly how money reaches a resident of a country with limited payment access — locally and from abroad.

Every figure is traceable to a published source listed in the Sources & Further Reading section, or is clearly labelled as an example.

What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not legal, tax, financial or investment advice. It is not a list of platforms that will approve you. It does not guarantee a client, a reply, a price, a payout method or a result of any kind.

It cannot tell you what a platform, a bank, a payment provider or a government office will decide about your specific case. That depends on your documents, your record and the rules in force on the day you apply.

FINANCIAL AND LEGAL DISCLAIMER

Nothing in this course is a guarantee of income. Any figure that looks like earnings is a **target example or arithmetic illustration, never a prediction**. Every price shown US US dollars (USD) is an example for teaching purposes; what you can charge depends on your market, your buyer and your proof.

You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you use. Rules, fees, limits, payout availability and country eligibility change without much warning. Verify anything you intend to rely on, on the official page, before you invest time or money in it.

This is not financial, legal or investment advice. For anything with a legal or tax consequence — licensing, TIN, turnover tax, VAT, contracts — confirm with your national tax authority or a qualified professional.

FICTIONAL EXAMPLES AND FIGURES

Every business, message, price and project in this course is invented to teach a method. Where a business name appears it is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. No real, recognisable local company is used as a client, a buyer or a success story anywhere in this course.

Figures cited are current as of **September 2026** unless a specific date is printed next to the figure. Source URLs for every statistic appear in the Sources & Further Reading section at the back of this course. Where this course could not verify a fact, it says so and tells you to check it yourself.

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Last updated: September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

What is inside this course

01 · What Freelancing From your country Actually Is 12
02 · Choose Your Skill and Your Niche 17
03 · Your Profile: Sell the Outcome, Not the CV 23
04 · A Portfolio Without Clients 29
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06 · Proposals and Outreach: Ten Scripts You Can Use Today 43
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10 · The 14-Day Launch Plan 67

HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.